

# After Action Review:

## Ecuador Earthquake

April – October 2016



*Empowered lives.  
Resilient nations.*



**UNDP Crisis Response Unit**

## Acknowledgements

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## List of Acronyms

|       |                                                             |
|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| AAR   | After Action Review                                         |
| BERA  | Bureau for External Relations and Advocacy                  |
| BMS   | Bureau of Management Support                                |
| BPPS  | Bureau for Policy and Programme Support                     |
| CB    | Crisis Board                                                |
| CERF  | Central Emergency Response Fund                             |
| CFW   | Cash For Work                                               |
| CMST  | Crisis Management Support Team                              |
| CO    | Country Office                                              |
| CRU   | Crisis Response Unit                                        |
| DRR   | Deputy Resident Representative                              |
| ER    | Early Recovery                                              |
| ERS   | Early Recovery Sector                                       |
| FTP   | Fast Track Procedures                                       |
| GCER  | Global Cluster on Early Recovery                            |
| HC    | Humanitarian coordinator                                    |
| IFI   | International Financial Institution                         |
| MIRA  | Multi-Sector Initial Rapid Assessment                       |
| NGO   | Non-governmental organization                               |
| OCHA  | Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs         |
| PDNA  | Post Disaster Needs Assessment                              |
| RBLAC | Regional Bureau for Latin America and the Caribbean         |
| RC    | Resident Coordinator                                        |
| RH    | Regional Hub                                                |
| RM    | Resource mobilization                                       |
| RR    | Resident Representative                                     |
| SOPs  | Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response |
| UNCT  | United Nations Country Team                                 |

# Executive Summary

## Introduction

On the 16<sup>th</sup> April 2016 a 7.8 magnitude earthquake struck the northwestern provinces of Ecuador, causing almost 700 victims while 16,600 people were injured, and 80,000 people were displaced. The provinces most affected were Esmeraldas and Manabí. Three days after the earthquake, the UNDP Crisis Board activated a Level 2 corporate support the Country Office (CO). First Responders (FRs) were deployed and shortly afterwards a SURGE Planning Team. The resulting SURGE Plan identified the support required for a period of three to six months, articulating UNDP's strategic vision for the response in four pillars: national leadership, emergency response, recovery and reconstruction, and productive reactivation.

## Analysis of the Response

### *UNDP in-country structure and management of the response*

The Ecuador CO was moderately prepared to face an emergency, and in fact the limited number of staff experienced or trained in crisis response had an initial impact on the activities. Nevertheless, the CO immediately appointed a Crisis Response Team constituted by staff from the Risk Management and the Local Development Units, as well as from Communications and Operations. The Deputy Resident Representative (DRR) led the CO response. Management had the merit to establish rapidly the crisis response unit, and to identify key staff for the response, not on the basis of their positions but rather on their skills, which contributed to the effectiveness of the response.

The establishment of a field office in the affected area, close to the national response and recovery coordination structures, was a key strategic decision that positioned UNDP well towards authorities and partners and facilitated coordination and implementation of activities.

### *Corporate response*

The Crisis Board, led by the Regional Director, supported the CO as needed in mobilizing the corporate response, however, there was a weaker follow-up on resource mobilization and on gender issues. The CB should have followed up more closely with the CO on the gender-responsiveness of its programmatic activities, according to UNDP's global commitment of dedicating 15% of the resources to gender equality and women's empowerment.

Coordination between different levels of the organization worked reasonably well, with the exception of an irregular Crisis Management Support Team (CMST). However informants have highlighted a challenge to involve effectively UNDP personnel for programme support at HQ and regional hub level.

Reported issues include limited information sharing, limited participation, lack of budget for field missions. But they point towards a more substantive problem that goes beyond the case of Ecuador. Programmatic support to the country office should be sustained from the initial response actions up to a more structured and comprehensive set of recovery and resilience building initiatives. Programmatic support could be useful not only during the response but could further help the CO transform the initial vision of the SURGE Plan, into a more structured one for recovery planning.

The First Responders deployments are considered very positive; the SURGE Planning Team contribution is also judged favorably by the different stakeholders interviewed. The SURGE Plan that resulted is a comprehensive document that highlights the immediate priorities and the medium-term vision for the CO, based on the initial needs and resources potentially available. It is considered by the CO a useful tool to focus and define priorities, which also guided decisions on resource mobilization and interagency coordination. It was, however, ambitious with regards to resource mobilization—aiming at \$80 million.

In order to tailor SURGE Plans better to the evolving circumstances of crisis response, UNDP could foresee a review of the Plan two or three months after its formulation; this review and the resources required should be factored in the initial version of the SURGE Plan. The review should result either in an adaptation of the Plan to changed circumstances or in the basis for the recovery framework to be further developed.

### *Deployment of experts*

Overall, the views on the effectiveness of the SURGE support are mixed. Twenty-six positions were initially foreseen in the SURGE Plan, articulated in: Post Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA), Government advisory functions, programme management, project implementation, enabling functions (coordination and communications), and operations. The majority of the SURGE support provided—by other COs, by MSB and by several consultants recruited—was successful. The SURGE support on programme management and project implementation functioned well, and it positioned UNDP towards Governments and partners, thanks to the successful and rapid implementation of activities. The Government advisory support instead did not achieve the expected impact, in part due to limited openness of some national entities to receiving support and due to the approach of some SURGE deployees. Some of the deployments were in fact shortened or reassigned.

To minimize unsuccessful deployments, UNDP should take measures to improve the selection and matching of SURGE deployees with the assignment and context in which they will operate; in particular more precise negotiations and agreement with receiving entities on the support required and deliverables expected, would be helpful.

Among the positions that were not deployed (by Government decision), the Early Recovery/Gender<sup>1</sup> Advisor support could have been prioritized. Gender equality is often de-prioritized in emergency response, with the excuse of urgency and prevalence of other needs; however, it is demonstrated that crises exacerbate existing inequalities, and therefore, working on gender issues is extremely relevant. An Early Recovery/Gender Advisor could have also articulated better the relevance of Early Recovery (ER) to the RC/HC and the Humanitarian Country Team (HCT), thus reducing the resistance and sometimes hostility that UNDP encountered on the matter.

In the end, the SURGE mechanism has shown its flexibility in allowing the CO to access different types of support according to its needs, flexibility confirmed through the SURGE review mission, which highlighted further support needed and recommended the extension of twelve positions.

### *Programmatic response*

UNDP's programmes were pertinent as they were coherent with national priorities, addressed the needs identified during assessments and some gaps in the existing response (particularly in rural areas and with the most vulnerable population); leveraged UNDP's expertise and added value. Some reservations have been expressed on the extent of their coverage and the geographic target; this is mostly linked to the assertive Government leadership and indications, and to the lack of resources for further expansion of coverage. Gender issues were not addressed systematically and therefore results could have been better with a more intentional and systematic approach.

The Ecuador experience represents an interesting case of innovation and adaptation of existing livelihood programming methodologies (En Marcha! and Creciendo con Su Negocio) to an emergency context, fostered by the fruitful collaboration between the CO and SURGE support. The packages developed are easily replicable and have in fact been used recently in other emergency contexts like Haiti and Mexico. With the opportune adaptations (including addressing the gender dimension), they should be included in UNDP's Crisis Response Packages as possible tools for livelihoods recovery.

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<sup>1</sup> The initial proposal for SURGE support was an ER Advisor with gender focus (summarized in ER/Gender Advisor). The CO could have also considered the separation of the 2 positions in an ER Advisor and a Gender Advisor, this however would have required more resources.

UNDP's programmatic impact could be improved by a systematic design of interventions as mutually reinforcing, in particular those that aim at building or strengthening resilience. Some of the activities implemented for crisis response and early recovery effectively built on each other, while in other projects the different components functioned in parallel. According to the CO, this is linked to the donor requirement of a consortium project and needs being identified separately and in advance by the implementing organizations, which led to separated interventions.

The three-track approach adopted by UNDP in its programmes (livelihoods stabilization, economic recovery and economic reintegration and inclusive growth) links early recovery interventions to longer-term recovery. However, the CO did not elaborate a formal recovery framework, and the one outlined in the SURGE Plan became infeasible when the prospective funds from IFIs were not assigned to UNDP. During the period object of this Review, the CO addressed five of the six areas of support to Governments on recovery planning.<sup>2</sup> It supported the National Committee for Reconstruction and Recovery by seconding an Advisor; it contributed to the hybrid PDNA/DALA assessment; it contributed to national recovery planning by developing the chapter on productive reactivation; it supported local authorities in designing livelihood recovery strategies for Manabí and Esmeraldas provinces, as well as by including disaster risk management in local operational plans and developing community and local governments contingency plans; it contributed to "Building back better" through the development of updated construction norms through one of its projects.

### *Operational response*

The CO/Operations team preparedness and training on emergencies was limited, as it was the use of CRPs. Future crisis response trainings for COs should increase the space dedicated to Operations for better preparedness.

Corporate support provided through First Responders and SURGE deployments was rapid and effective. The CO opened rapidly a field office in Manta, which was a very efficient and successful strategic decision.

All informants interviewed consider exigency measures useful and effective, and some improvements have been proposed, in particular on the extent of due diligence required before contracting vendors or partners during emergencies. This is a challenge often experienced in crises: finding the elusive balance between speed of action and adequate controls.

### *Interagency coordination and engagement with Government and partners*

Within the humanitarian community, UNDP experienced widespread resistance on the importance of early recovery and on the criticality of its proposed interventions. More traditional humanitarian sectors were given priority; as a consequence, potential CERF funding was reduced, and UNDP chose to withdraw from CERF. The MIRA was a slow and late process, to which UNDP indicates no ER sector member was invited, it consolidated information from multiple assessments mostly focusing on agency mandates; comprehensive information on early recovery was not included.

While recognizing the evident resistance UNDP encountered, a general lack of coordination in this phase reduced UNDP's capacity to mainstream ER in other assessments, however, it appears that UNDP did not engage substantively with other sectors to this effect, reportedly for lack of resources.

UNDP as ER sector lead complied with its responsibilities of national coordination, information management, and contribution to humanitarian appeals, but was less effective on other areas, and once SURGE support ended, the motivation faded to continue sustaining the small sector and the organization focused more on internal issues. The ER sector became mainly a forum for information sharing of different members.

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<sup>2</sup> The six areas of support to Governments on Recovery Planning and Coordination, are: Institutional Arrangements for Recovery, Post Disaster Needs Assessments, Recovery Planning, Managing Recovery, Building Back Better and Managing Residual Risks, Resource Mobilization. UNDP, *Guidance Note on National Post-Disaster Recovery Planning and Coordination*, (2017).

UNDP's prompt engagement in support to the national and subnational response, the positive results achieved on debris management and livelihoods recovery positioned the organization well with the Government of Ecuador, both at national and subnational level. National authorities interviewed have repeatedly noted the superior contribution provided by staff in the CO, revealing how long-term relations and trust are more effective than technical expertise in influencing authorities and positioning the organization.

The PDNA process presented some initial difficulties: despite the PDNA training organized by UNDP in the months before the earthquake, the Government accepted an offer from the Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean (ECLAC) to conduct instead a Damage and Loss Assessment (DALA), later asking for a combined assessment methodology. In the end, the assessment was conducted using the two complementary methodologies of PDNA and DALA that were later integrated in the final Ministry of Planning report. The divergences on PDNA in Ecuador are likely to be repeated in other countries unless a political agreement is reached with ECLAC. Despite the setbacks, UNDP was able to mainstream the recovery agenda into the PDNA.

### *Communications and resource mobilization*

UNDP's was rapid and effective in completing a three-weeks communications campaign, "Ecuador Aquí Estoy" that was very successful and original. It was an example of innovative forms of communication oriented to resource mobilization (RM), that UNDP should continue exploring especially in middle-income countries with reduced RM opportunities from traditional donors.

Communications activities were also aimed at traditional donors, who provided resources to UNDP thanks to the previous relationship with the organization and trust in its methods of work, expertise and mandate; the coincidence between Government and donors' priorities and UNDP proposed interventions; UNDP's capacity and speed of delivery; gaps in early recovery funding (as other sectors were better covered by other donors).

Interviewed Staff highlighted that more preparedness and trainings on how to manage communications during an emergency would be useful, not only for the communications team but also for programme managers. First Responders, regional and SURGE support was deemed very useful and the CO team appreciated it.

UNDP mobilized over USD 3.95 million in additional resources. The organization immediately recognized the importance of RM and the role that the private sector could play in the Ecuador context, however a Resource Mobilization Action Plan (RMAP) or a RM strategy was not formally developed, and there were no RM Advisors deployed with SURGE. This could have been useful, particularly when expected funds from IFIs were channeled instead to other entities.

The Central Emergency Response Fund (CERF) released USD 7 millions, prioritizing logistics, shelter, WASH and emergency health. UNDP was initially involved in CERF discussions and had planned to submit requests for USD 500,000, as part of the proposal from the Shelter cluster. There was considerable resistance from other humanitarian organizations and the newly appointed Humanitarian Coordinator indicated that UNDP had to reduce its proposal to USD 250,000. After consultations, management considered it insufficient for the activities planned and UNDP withdrew its participation from CERF.

Several key informants interviewed,<sup>3</sup> including from the CO, consider in hindsight that UNDP could have accepted participating in CERF, despite the halving of its proposal and the strong tensions with other humanitarian organizations. Others believe that UNDP took the right decision in withdrawing, as the reduction of UNDP funds to assign them to another organization was unacceptable.

The Flash Appeal estimated the costs for emergency response and early recovery in USD 72.8 millions, prioritizing "multi-sector life-saving assistance, protection services and immediate livelihood restoration". Overall it was funded at approximately 38%. The ER sector, which targeted 100,000 people and required USD 7 millions, around 10% of the total appeal.

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<sup>3</sup> Not all stakeholders agree with this finding.

In a difficult RM environment like Ecuador, where there is a strong and capable Government, a limited donor base and reduced opportunities for traditional RM, UNDP should both explore alternative RM options and take a strategic approach influencing the use of Government's available funds to address the needs of the most vulnerable. Alternative RM opportunities can include: approaching philanthropic foundations based in or with ties to the country, engaging the private sector through corporate social responsibility, targeting private citizens and the diaspora through RM tools like crowd-funding. In fact, UNDP Ecuador showed remarkable creativity in developing a very successful communications and resource mobilizations campaign, aimed more at the public and the private sector than at traditional donors.

## Concluding observations

**1. Middle-income countries with high human development and strong national capacity require a different approach.** The CO naturally understood this, and was able to organize the response according to the context: it adapted successfully programmatic tools used for development to the emergency situation; it used an innovative approach to resource mobilization; it also leveraged existing national capacities and made an intentional effort to strengthen them even further.

**2. UNDP's progressive professionalization on crisis response is bearing fruits and the organization should be strategic in its commitment and investments to increase results even further.** The Crisis response SOPs, the Crisis Response Packages, Fast Track Procedures, SURGE support and all the other tools available are effective in supporting a CO with limited preparedness and limited experience in crisis management to deliver a positive response.

**3. Within the humanitarian community, UNDP experienced widespread resistance on the importance of early recovery and on the criticality of its proposed interventions at the beginning of the crisis, including from the Humanitarian Coordinator (HC).**

Despite the progress made over the years, the acceptance of early recovery remains a challenge in crisis contexts, limiting UNDP's space, priority and resources. Both in the CERF and the Flash Appeal, other humanitarian sectors were given priority over Early Recovery; resulting in UNDP's withdrawal from CERF. Moreover, despite UNDP's insistence, the MIRA was conducted without taking the ER sector into account.

## Recommendations

### *Crisis response preparedness*

- ☑ **[ECO]<sup>4</sup>** *Given the permanent and the recurring disaster risks faced by Ecuador, the CO should continue strengthening its internal preparedness, by regularly exposing key staff (programmes and operations alike) to all corporate support facilities and mechanisms, by allowing the deployment of qualified staff, especially national staff, to other operations as SURGE support or First Responders (a good practice the CO is already implementing), and by ensuring the annual update and implementation of Minimum Preparedness Actions (MPAs) and of the BCP. In case of a heightened risk of disaster, ensure Advanced Preparedness Actions are completed on time.*
- ☑ **[ECO]** *The CO should test its preparedness and capacity by conducting internal emergency simulations or participating in interagency ones that feature key disaster risks, like a Cotopaxi eruption. Based on the simulation results, the CO shall improve and update its preparedness, addressing identified weaknesses.*

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<sup>4</sup> [ECO] refers to Ecuador Country Office, while [COs] recommendations are valid for COs in general.

- ☑ **[ECO]** The CO as part of its preparedness efforts should engage regularly with Government (especially with national-level entities involved in disaster risk management), donors and partners on the relevance of Early Recovery in emergencies, building on the WHS commitment on transcending the humanitarian-development divide towards collective outcomes, as articulated in the “New Way of Working” approach, preparing the space for UNDP’s role on ER during a crisis.
- ☑ **[ECO]** The CO should invest in communications preparedness activities, including developing in advance customizable communications products and messages for key target audiences on the main risks the country faces (for example the Cotopaxi eruption). It should ensure that both programme managers and communications staff are trained on communications in emergency.
- ☑ **[CRU] [RBx] [BMS]** CRU, BMS and Regional Bureaux should invest more in the preparedness of Operations teams across regions, by:
  - ✓ Expanding the component on Operations and special measures (previously called FTPs) in CRP/preparedness trainings;
  - ✓ Continue to train the Operations Managers of all COs, and one or two key staff per CO;
  - ✓ Continue to increase internal capacity through FR/SURGE deployments and detail missions of COs Operations staff.
- ☑ **[CRU]** CRU should ensure regular distribution and communication on CRPs to increase their diffusion and knowledge by COs; evaluate the opportunity of translating into French, Spanish and Arabic the CRPs components currently in English (only Guidance Notes are translated).

#### Gender equality

- ☑ **[CB] [CMST]** The Crisis Board should ensure it addresses gender issues as provided for by the SOPs; during these meetings it should hold the CO’s Management accountable on UNDP’s gender commitments (dedicate 15% of its funds to address women specific needs, advance gender equality, empower women and girls as the primary objective), including by requesting reports on progress towards the commitments; the CMST with technical support from BPPS/Regional Gender Specialists should ensure regular follow-up on gender-related decisions and provide technical assistance to the CO if needed.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS/Gender]** CRU and BPPS/Gender Team should review the specific ToRs of the FR and SURGE deployees before any specific deployment to ensure that they include clear and measurable responsibilities and deliverables on gender, linked to the crisis, in line with UNDP’s global commitment on gender taken at the World Humanitarian Summit (15% of resources dedicated to gender equality and women’s empowerment); gender expertise should be included as a desired requirement and prioritizing criterion for deployment; SURGE deployees performance should be assessed– where applicable - against the gender-related deliverables included in ToRs.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS/Gender]** CRU with the support of the BPPS Gender Team should mainstream gender into the First Responders and SURGE trainings, expanding from thematic sessions to all relevant subjects (for example assessments, response planning, recovery planning, signature products, case studies and simulations, and so on).
- ☑ **[ECO]** With support from BPPS and the Regional Gender Team, the CO should take a more systematic and structured approach towards gender equality and women’s empowerment, including in assessments, programme planning and implementation, and programme monitoring, as well as ensure the same approach in the Early Recovery sector. If needed, technical support and specialized expertise are available to help the CO fulfill UNDP’s global commitments on gender (dedicate 15% of its funds to address women specific needs, advance gender equality, empower women and girls as the primary objective)
- ☑ **[COs] [BPPS]** UNDP COs with the support of PDNA Advisors if deployed, and in collaboration with UN Women if present in-country, should ensure the mainstreaming of gender issues in the entirety of PDNAs,

particularly in sectorial analyses, so that different needs of women and men, boys and girls can be addressed in the recovery and reconstruction plans that are developed on the basis of these assessments.

- ☑ **[CRU]** CRU, with the support from BPPS/Gender, should include the gender dimension in standard AARs Terms of Reference and a minimum number of questions to orient AARs on the subject.

#### Corporate support

- ☑ **[CRU]** When developing the SURGE Plan, the Planning Team and the CO should assess the need for BPPS technical support to the CO design of the Recovery Framework/Plan, and if pertinent, include it as part of SURGE support towards the end of the SURGE phase. If any BPPS staff are deployed as First Responders, they can contribute to this analysis by joining the SURGE Planning Team. After the end of the SURGE phase, further BPPS technical support shall be funded through other mechanisms different from SURGE.
- ☑ **[CRU]** As the situation after a disaster is very dynamic, UNDP should provide for a review of the SURGE Plan two/three months after the initial formulation (either remotely or through a CRU/RB/BPPS joint mission, depending on the specifics of each crisis); this review should be factored in the initial version of the SURGE Plan; it should include a programmatic analysis of the CO portfolio and crisis response implemented; its result could be either an evolution of the initial SURGE Plan which takes into account the changes in the country situation and the potential resources that can be mobilized, or the basis to design long-term recovery programmes, the Recovery Framework for the CO or support to national recovery planning.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS]** CRU and BPPS should articulate more in detail the transition between the crisis and recovery phases by outlining specific roles and responsibilities of UNDP's offices and departments, possible support available and how COs can access it.
- ☑ **[CB]** The CB should ensure the regularity of the CMST, created to support and monitor the implementation of CB decisions and CO required support; to this effect it should appoint a CMST Coordinator that is not deployed elsewhere during the first weeks of the crisis.
- ☑ **[CRU]** AARs should be conducted maximum after 6 months from the response as indicated in the SOPs.

#### Deployment of experts

- ☑ **[CRU] [COs]** UNDP should take measures to reduce the risk of unsuccessful deployments by improving the selection and matching of consultants' profiles with their assignments:
  - ✓ CRU should expand the Spanish-speaking profiles in the ExpRes roster by engaging with LAC COs to identify potential candidates (both practitioners and in academia) and by engaging with Latin American qualified diaspora;
  - ✓ COs should negotiate in advance with national authorities and receiving entities, defining precise ToRs of SURGE positions, adapted to the crisis and clearly indicating the specific support required and deliverables expected; these can also be reviewed after a while as crisis situations are highly dynamic and needs might change;
  - ✓ UNDP should provide for dynamic assessment of the effectiveness of SURGE deployments by establishing benchmarks or progressive deliverables in the ToRs, and for the rapid reallocation of SURGE deployees to different tasks or institutions in case of a change in circumstances or support required.
- ☑ **[CRU]** If UNDP wants to position itself globally on some of its signature products, for example as the go-to organization for debris management in an emergency, it should hire full-time experts who are global authorities on the chosen subject and who develop knowledge through practice, studies and publications. If funding limitations would not allow hiring full-time experts, UNDP should consider sourcing experts from the private sector (accepting the higher cost this entails) for short-term needs.

## Programmes

- ☑ **[ECO]** The CO should strengthen its programmatic impact by ensuring a systematic design of interventions as mutually reinforcing and integrated, in particular those that aim at building or strengthening resilience.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS]** CRU and BPPS should review the Ecuador CO adaptation of the two livelihoods methodologies (*En Marcha!* and *Creciendo con Su Negocio*) as potential tools for inclusion into the CRPs.

## Operations

- ☑ **[BMS]** CRU/BMS/RBx should continue to disseminate regularly information on special measures (previously called FTPs) for better awareness of COs on the procedures and policies available for countries in crisis
- ☑ **[BMS]** UNDP should assess the added value of all documentation required before contracting a vendor or a partner in crisis response, balancing rapidity of implementation with due diligence and accountability.

## Interagency coordination and engagement with broader response

- ☑ **[CRU] [GCER]** UNDP, in collaboration with the members of the Global Cluster on Early Recovery (GCER), could lead the development and global endorsement of Early Recovery Standards complementary to the Sphere Standards, taking advantage of the opportunity presented by the New Way of Working. This should be done in addition to the integration of ER in existing standards (already occurring).
- ☑ **[COs]** During a crisis UNDP COs must engage robustly on cluster/sector lead responsibilities, taking a proactive approach to building consensus around early recovery. In case of limited resources available to ER cluster/sector members and gaps in the response, UNDP COs should advocate with Government, donors and humanitarian agencies to ensure that early recovery gaps are addressed through the resources of other clusters/sectors, by taking a cross-cluster approach to early recovery.
- ☑ **[RBLAC]** UNDP, together with the World Bank and the European Union, should negotiate an agreement with ECLAC on needs assessments after a crisis, with the corresponding standard procedures and methodology to be used in case of crises in Latin America and the Caribbean.
- ☑ **[COs] [BPPS]** In PDNA or similar assessment exercises, UNDP should continue to emphasize the “soft” components of recovery, in particular the public policies, systems and governance that foster recovery beyond reconstruction.

## Communications

- ☑ **[ECO]** UNDP communications products and campaigns should highlight, together with the agency work, the activities of the ER cluster/sector, thus fulfilling its sector’s lead responsibility to advocate for and engage on behalf of the entire ER cluster/sector.
- ☑ **[COs] [RBx]** UNDP should continue ensuring maximum visibility in key humanitarian communication products like SitReps, especially at the beginning of a crisis when information is scarce and SitReps are one of the main sources of information for donors and humanitarian partners alike.
- ☑ **[RBx] [BERA]** In middle-income countries where opportunities for traditional RM are limited, UNDP should expand its RM strategy by imitating Ecuador’s example with communications campaigns aimed at individual donations. Communications campaigns should involve Goodwill Ambassadors, celebrities, artists, athletes and others with high social mobilization potential in the country, leveraging their social media presence to engage both the country’s citizens and diaspora. It is recommended to identify possible Goodwill Ambassadors (or similar roles) for middle-income countries and engage them in communications for UNDP, not only for emergencies but also for non-crisis activities.

## Resource Mobilization

- ☑ **[CB]** *The Crisis Board should ensure a stricter adherence to the SOPs on Resource Mobilization (by verifying that a RM mobilization strategy, even if basic, is always developed and that it is reviewed in case of major changes in the expected funding) and it should demand dedicated support to the CO from BERA and the respective RB in case of a difficult RM environment with limited opportunities for raising funds; the respective scope and interplay of BERA's and RB's resource mobilization support to a CO during crisis response should be better defined in the SOPs and in practice.*
- ☑ **[BERA]** *BERA should develop guidance on RM strategies for middle-income countries that take an alternative approach to RM, target private citizens, diaspora, philanthropic foundations and the private sector, taking example from fundraising strategies in Western countries by other humanitarian and development organizations and exploring new fundraising strategies like crowd-funding.*
- ☑ **[ECO]** *The CO, with support from CRU and BERA, should evaluate the opportunity of joining the Connecting Business Initiatives.*

# 1. Introduction

## 1.1 Country situation and context

Ecuador is a middle-income country with a Human Development Index (HDI) in 2015 of 0.739, ranking 88<sup>th</sup> out of 189 countries – it is classified as a high human development country. The Inequality-adjusted HDI (IHDI) shows a 20% loss of human development due to inequality, while the Gender Inequality Index (GII), with a value of 0.391, ranks Ecuador 88th out of 159 countries for which the index was calculated in 2015.<sup>5</sup>

On the 16<sup>th</sup> April 2016 a 7.8 magnitude earthquake struck the northwestern provinces, causing almost 700 victims while 16,600 people were injured, and round 80,000 people were displaced. The provinces most affected were Esmeraldas and Manabí, Santa Elena, Guayas, Santo Domingo and Los Ríos, declared by the Government in “state of emergency”. The canton of Pedernales in Manabí was declared a disaster zone.

Both Esmeraldas and Manabí present indicators of poverty and vulnerability well beyond the national average. For example, while the Non-satisfied Basic Needs Indicator (a multi-dimensional poverty indicator) is 33% for the entire country, it is 49% in Esmeraldas and 53% in Manabí. The unemployment rate is 4.8% nationally, 7.8% in Esmeraldas and 6.1% in Manabí.<sup>6</sup> In addition to the general higher vulnerability of the affected areas, certain groups are even more vulnerable. For example, women and girls in the lowest income quintile, Afro-Ecuadorians and native populations face more difficulties than others in access to basic services; gender-based violence (GBV) prevalence is 58% in Esmeraldas and 48% in Manabí; sexual violence is 25% and 15% respectively – according to a 2011 study conducted by the national Statistics Institute.<sup>7</sup>

**Three days after the earthquake, the UNDP Crisis Board activated a Level 2 corporate support the Country Office (CO) on immediate response, early recovery and recovery.** First Responders (FRs) were quickly deployed and shortly afterwards a SURGE Planning Team traveled to Ecuador. The resulting SURGE Plan identified the support required for a period of three to six months, articulating UNDP’s strategic vision for the response in four pillars: national leadership, emergency response, recovery and reconstruction, and productive reactivation.

## 1.2 Objectives and methodology of the After Action Review

After corporate crisis response activation, UNDP conducts After Action Reviews (AARs) to learn from the experience and improve its future performance. The AAR is as a “structured reflection after a crisis that helps the organization to identify strengths and weaknesses, positive and negative lessons learned, how to sustain what was done well and identify areas for improvement.” The objective and scope of the present AAR are “to examine the performance of UNDP with respect to the response to the crisis in Ecuador from April to October 2016”. The AAR will highlight lessons learned that would help strengthen the functioning, performance and efficiency of UNDP response to sudden onset crisis, including: UNDPs corporate and country level programmatic and operational response; UN and interagency coordination; contribution to Post Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA) and recovery processes.”<sup>8</sup>

Six primary questions, articulated into 36 sub-questions,<sup>9</sup> have been identified to assess **the effectiveness of UNDP’s overall crisis response.**

<sup>5</sup> UNDP, Human Development Report 2016 – Ecuador.

<sup>6</sup> OCHA, Multi-Sectorial Initial Rapid Assessment.

<sup>7</sup> OCHA, Ibid.

<sup>8</sup> Terms of Reference “After Action Review of UNDP response to the Ecuador Earthquake”, 2017.

<sup>9</sup> See the data collection matrix in Annex 5.

They are:

1. How timely and efficient was the use of the SOPs tools and mechanisms for crisis response?
2. How efficient was the UNDP SURGE mechanism (i.e. the UNDP staff and expert's deployment mechanism)?
3. How effective was UNDP engagement with the broader response (including government and humanitarian partners)?
4. How relevant and effective was the programmatic response of UNDP?
5. How effective the operational response of UNDP?
6. How effective were UNDP's external communications and resource mobilisation?

The AAR was conducted in three phases: data collection, analysis, and reporting. The data collection phase included a desk review of all the documentation provided by the CO, CRU and RBLAC; the identification of key stakeholders<sup>10</sup> for Key Informant Interviews (KII) in person or online, Focus Group Discussions (FGD) in Ecuador or online, a one-week mission to Ecuador at the beginning of October 2017 to meet with key stakeholders in Quito, and a field visit to the province of Manabí to meet with local authorities, partners and beneficiaries.

UNDP's response is assessed against criteria of relevance, efficiency, effectiveness and where applicable sustainability, on the basis of the documentation and the interviews conducted. The purpose of this analysis is to understand what worked well and what could have been done better or differently, according to the AAR methodology, and to identify actionable recommendations for the CO and the organization at large to improve its response in the future.

In order to validate findings, conclusions and recommendations, a preliminary report is shared with key stakeholders and presented to AAR participants, notable CRU, RBLAC, HQ Bureaus and the Country Office. The final report will be compiled afterwards and will be accompanied by a two-pager to be shared with external stakeholders.

**A note for future AARs:** AARs should take place no later than 6 months after the activation of the response. The Ecuador one takes place 18 months afterwards, limiting to a certain extent data collection, interviews with key stakeholders and focus group discussions, as many of the UNDP staff involved in the earthquake response have changed positions or are not available, documents are more difficult to retrieve and the memory of the facts is less sharp. Due to the absence of most of the staff involved in the response at the time of the mission in country, it was not possible to conduct an AAR workshop. In addition, the distance in time and the number of crises that happened since 2016 has significantly diminished the interest in this AAR, as other more recent crises are (understandably) more prominent now. Also, the initial ToRs, contrary to the indications of the SOPs, did not include any question on gender equality.

## 2. Analysis of the UNDP Response

The report structures the analysis of the overall UNDP response in 8 main parts:

1. The Ecuador context and other factors that have influenced the response;
2. A brief overview of the main events between April and December 2017, either within UNDP or external;
3. Ecuador CO management of the crisis;
4. Corporate support, including the Crisis Board, the SURGE planning phase, First Responders deployments and the SURGE follow up mission;
5. SURGE support and deployments;

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<sup>10</sup> A list of key stakeholders involved is included in Annex 7.2.

6. Programmatic aspects of the response;
7. Operational aspects of the response;
8. Interagency coordination and engagement with Government and partners;
9. Communications and resource mobilization.

## 2.1 Contextual factors influencing the response

Ecuador is a middle-income country with a high human development index, where the international community is more focused and experienced on development than on humanitarian action. Preparedness initiatives had taken place since 2015 due to the Cotopaxi volcano risk of eruption, however the number of international actors is limited, in particular in the Early Recovery (ER) sector. A 2013 law on non-governmental and civil society organizations, which imposed restrictions on NGOs, had also affected the presence of international NGOs in Ecuador.

The Government of Ecuador (GoE) took on strongly the leadership of response and recovery, investing on reconstruction the funds generated through a “Law of Solidarity” and channeling most of the loans through its Ministries and institutions. In part, this was related to the impending 2017 Presidential elections. The contribution of external actors—such as the UN—was appreciated, but considered supplementary to the national effort. Such strong leadership from Ecuador authorities is appreciated as the country takes ownership of its own reconstruction and development; at the same time, it has affected UNDP’s (and others’) ability to influence authorities on the response and recovery, and it has reduced opportunities for resource mobilization—already limited by a small donor community in the country.

## 2.2 Timeline of crisis events and response actions

Below a summary of the main events from April to December 2016:

| External or interagency                                                                                                                                                                      | Date               | UNDP                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>APRIL</b>       |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 7.8 magnitude earthquake strikes Ecuador causing almost 700 deaths, over 16,000 people injured and approximately 80,000 people displaced                                                     | <b>16 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Government requests international support for needs assessment and response coordination, including for the medical response                                                                 | <b>16 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>17 April</b>    | Activation of Fast Track Procedures and immediate opening of a Direct Implementation project (Fuerza Ecuador)                                                                                          |
| Government declares state of emergency in worst affected provinces                                                                                                                           | <b>17 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| UNDAC deployed to support on-site coordination in the towns of Manta, Porto Viejo, Pedernales and Quito; OCHA deploys                                                                        | <b>17 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| European Civil Protection mechanism activated upon UN request                                                                                                                                | <b>17 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| The European Union has released one million euros of emergency assistance for victims.                                                                                                       | <b>17 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Government activates a line of credit for US\$600 million for recovery and reconstruction efforts                                                                                            | <b>17 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ERC visit to Ecuador                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>18-19 April</b> |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>18 April</b>    | Fuerza Ecuador project initiated, for one year. Funding from UNDP (650,000), civil society (150,000), private sector (250,000)                                                                         |
|                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>19 Apr</b>      | CB#1 - Level 2 corporate response activated; USD 150,000 allocated from TRAC 113 for ER coordination and assessments and; and USD 500,000 to start the response; deployment of first responders agreed |
| Humanitarian coordination hubs set up in Quito, Guayaquil, Portoviejo, Manta                                                                                                                 | <b>19 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>19 April</b>    | First Responders deployed (1 ER Cluster Coordo, 1 Debris Mgmt. Expert, 1 Comms Specialist, 1 Procurement Expert)                                                                                       |
| UN Resident Coordinator designated as Humanitarian Coordinator                                                                                                                               | <b>20 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Inter-American Development Bank (IDB) activates a contingency loan of US\$300 million to support the Ecuadorian Government with losses and emergency expenses associated with the earthquake | <b>20 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

|                                                                                                                                                        |                    |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CERF allocates US\$7 million for three months for logistics, shelter, water, sanitation and hygiene, and health programs                               | <b>21 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>21 April</b>    | Allocation of USD 500,000 emergency funding to CO                                                                                                                   |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>22 April</b>    | Donation of USD 99,940 from Repsol Foundation                                                                                                                       |
| Flash Appeal launched - 72.75 USD million                                                                                                              | <b>22 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                     |
| WB loans USD 150 million to Ecuador for emergency recovery                                                                                             | <b>22 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>25th April</b>  | CB#2                                                                                                                                                                |
| President constitutes the Reconstruction and Productive Reactivation Committee                                                                         | <b>26th April</b>  |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>27 April</b>    | Deployment SURGE Environment Specialist (standby partner, 3 months) (first deployment)                                                                              |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>27 April</b>    | Deployment SURGE PDNA coordinator (1 month)(first deployment)                                                                                                       |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>28 April</b>    | SURGE Planning team deployed from 28 April to 5th May 2016                                                                                                          |
| Revised Flash Appeal                                                                                                                                   | <b>28 April</b>    |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>April</b>       | Deployment of SURGE support (several positions) throughout April and May                                                                                            |
| Negotiations over needs assessment methodology (PDNA vs. DALA)                                                                                         | <b>April</b>       |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>April</b>       | Meeting with IDB, possible funding for USD 35 millions (later given to Government)                                                                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                        |                    | Meeting with EIB (which assigned USD 105 million to Ecuador crisis) - interested in partnering with UNDP                                                            |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>MAY</b>         |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>May</b>         | Deployment of SURGE support (several positions) April to July                                                                                                       |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>2 May</b>       | CB#3                                                                                                                                                                |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>2 May</b>       | Pilot Project on debris removal starts in Las Gilces                                                                                                                |
| PDNA starts                                                                                                                                            | <b>3 May</b>       |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>3 May</b>       | Deployment SURGE ER Cluster Coordinator (3 months)                                                                                                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>4 May</b>       | Deployment SURGE Senior Recovery Advisor to VP (3 months)                                                                                                           |
| MIRA report presented                                                                                                                                  | <b>10 May</b>      |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>11 May</b>      | Regional Director RBLAC mission to Ecuador (until 16 May)                                                                                                           |
| Aquí Estoy Ecuador - concert in Miami                                                                                                                  | <b>11 May</b>      |                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Aquí Estoy Ecuador - concert in Quito                                                                                                                  | <b>15 May</b>      |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>17 May</b>      | CB#4 - SURGE Plan Approved                                                                                                                                          |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>23 May</b>      | Official opening of the Manta field office (closed on 31st August 2017)                                                                                             |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>May</b>         | 6 months pilot project En Marcha in Las Gilces for reconstruction and livelihoods recovery                                                                          |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>May</b>         | 3 months Project En Marcha in Manta                                                                                                                                 |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>JUNE</b>        |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>June</b>        | Deployment of SURGE support (several positions) April to July                                                                                                       |
| PDNA to be presented to the Government                                                                                                                 | <b>3 June</b>      |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>6 June</b>      | Three months project En Marcha in Pedernales, Manabí Province funded by Fons Català de Cooperació (USD 25,000)                                                      |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>9 June</b>      | Gov. of Kazakhstan donates USD 50,000 to UNDP for recovery                                                                                                          |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>17 June</b>     | Gov. of Japan donates USD 300,000 to UNDP for ER activities                                                                                                         |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>23 June</b>     | CB#5 - calls for a follow up mission to Ecuador after 3 months                                                                                                      |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>27 June</b>     | Deployment SURGE Recovery Programme Advisor (1 month)                                                                                                               |
| OCHA briefing in Geneva on Ecuador                                                                                                                     | <b>30 June</b>     |                                                                                                                                                                     |
| HC asks for extension of Flash Appeal and OCHA support to 6 months and for 2nd CERF grant                                                              | <b>June</b>        |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>JULY</b>        |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>July</b>        | Deployment of SURGE support (several positions) April to July                                                                                                       |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>7th July</b>    | IDV football team donates USD 807,000 to UNDP which will be used for the Livelihoods projects                                                                       |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>July</b>        | ECHO allocates USD 952,000 to UNDP                                                                                                                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>AUGUST</b>      |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>9-11 August</b> | Follow-up mission to Ecuador requested by CB takes place. Objective: review SURGE plan identifying existing gaps and support requirement for the following 3 months |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>August</b>      | Early Recovery through debris management project in Rio Chico, Manabí province, funded by Japan (USD 300,000)                                                       |
| Plan "Reconstruct Ecuador" by the Government                                                                                                           | <b>August</b>      |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|                                                                                                                                                        | <b>15 August</b>   | One-year project with UN Women and AVSF on livelihoods and emergency social protection in Manabí and Esmeraldas, funded by ECHO (USD 952,000)                       |
| HC requests UNDP to place focal points in the 3 subnational coordination hubs before 31st October and coordinate recovery work, after OCHA downscaling | <b>24th August</b> |                                                                                                                                                                     |

|                                                    |              |                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                    | 29th August  | One year livelihood recovery project in Manabí and Esmeraldas, funded by IDV football club       |
|                                                    | SEPTEMBER    |                                                                                                  |
|                                                    | September    | Extension of selected SURGE positions for three extra months (throughout September and October)  |
|                                                    | OCTOBER      |                                                                                                  |
|                                                    | October      | Extension of selected SURGE positions for three extra months (throughout September and October)  |
|                                                    | NOVEMBER     |                                                                                                  |
|                                                    | November     | UNDP drafts HCT strategy for livelihood recovery (check)                                         |
|                                                    | DECEMBER     |                                                                                                  |
| Humanitarian Country Team Lessons Learned Workshop | 7-8 December |                                                                                                  |
|                                                    | 12 December  | 6 months project En Marcha funded by Red Emprande (USD 100,000) starts in Manta, Manabí Province |

## 2.3 UNDP in-country structure and response capacity

### *Main developments*

**The Ecuador CO was moderately prepared to face an emergency.** It had updated its Business Continuity Plan (BCP) in 2015 and had conducted preparedness activities linked to the Cotopaxi volcano eruption risk in 2015 and the El Niño risk in 2016. In addition, in November 2015 there was a Post-Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA) training for UN and government officers. However, in the CO there were only very few staff trained on crisis response. When the earthquake happened, the BCP was immediately activated and for some days an alternate location was used until UNDP building was declared safe.

**Following the disaster, the CO immediately appointed a Crisis Response Coordinator and organized a Crisis Response Team constituted by staff from the Risk Management and the Local Development Units, as well as from Communications and Operations.** The Deputy Resident Representative (DRR) led the CO response with the support of the COCRT. In the following months, the initial team would evolve into the Emergency and Recovery Unit, and afterwards into its current form of the Inclusive Economic Development and Risk Management Unit. The CO deployed staff immediately to the affected areas for short-term missions and in slightly over a month it opened a field office in the city of Manta, in Manabí province. The field-office also reported to the Crisis and Recovery Unit.<sup>11</sup>

**Once the Resident Coordinator (RC) was appointed Humanitarian Coordinator (HC), the management of UNDP's CO response was mostly the responsibility of the DRR.** While retaining his responsibilities as Resident Representative and participating in most of the Crisis Board meetings, the RC/HC dedicated the majority of his time to his role of Humanitarian Coordinator.

### *Findings*

**The limited number of staff experienced or trained in crisis response had an initial impact on the response.** While it is clear that the CO was quick in reacting, decisive in re-organizing itself for the response and open to corporate support, a more extensive preparedness would have been beneficial, for example reducing in part the need for First Responders or SURGE support. Interviewed Staff have repeatedly expressed the need and interest for more preparedness and crisis response training. Before the crisis the CO had participated in one Crisis Response and Preparedness training led by CRU, and after the crisis in 2017 the CO was invited and

<sup>11</sup> See the section on the Manta field office in Chapter 2.7.

participated in another regional training. These initiatives are useful and should be disseminated within the CO.

**The CO Management had the merit to establish quickly the response team and then a well-organized crisis response unit, and to identify key staff for the response,** not on the basis of their positions but rather on their professional skills and strengths. Choosing the right staff with the right skills and investing in national staff has contributed greatly to the overall results. A further confirmation of the above is the later deployment of several staff involved in the Ecuador response to other emergencies.

**The establishment of a field office in the affected area, close to the national response and recovery coordination structures, was a key strategic decision** that positioned UNDP well towards authorities and partners and facilitated coordination and implementation of activities.

## 2.4 UNDP corporate response mechanisms

### *Main developments*

**The Crisis Board (CB) met three days after the earthquake and declared a Level 2 corporate activation.** As per SOPs for a Level 2 crisis, the Regional Bureau for Latin America and the Caribbean (RBLAC) took the leadership. The CB allocated USD 150,000 for coordination and assessments and USD 500,000 to kick-start the programmatic response. It also authorized the deployment of four First Responders (from CRU, RBLAC, and other COs) and of the SURGE Planning team.

**The CB approved resource allocation, deployments, and the SURGE Plan, and was a space for coordination and information sharing among UNDP Headquarters (HQ), RBLAC, the Panama Regional Hub (RH) and the Ecuador office.** In addition, it supported the CO on the negotiations about the needs assessment methodology. The GoE was considering two options, the Post-Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA) - traditionally promoted by UNDP, World Bank and the European Union - and the Damage and Loss Assessment (DALA) promoted by the Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean (ECLAC) and requested the UN to combine them. The Needs Assessment and its results are discussed more in detail in Chapter 2.8.

**The CB highlighted from the first meeting the importance of resource mobilization and in particular of the private sector,** stating that “UNDP needs to engage at different levels to leverage this support”.<sup>1213</sup> The same action point was still pending six days later after the second Crisis Board meeting. At the third meeting the CO suggested to have a dedicated conversation on financing of the response; there is however no recorded follow-up on the matter. Due to staff turnover, requests to interview any BERA staff involved in resource mobilization for the Ecuador crisis were inconclusive.

**The Regional Director (RD) traveled to Ecuador in May** and the mission was very beneficial as it supported the CO on the importance of early recovery (ER) and recovery with the Government and other humanitarian and development agencies; it validated the programmatic choices made by the CO and recognized the difficulties on resource mobilization; it also gave a psychological boost to the entire CO team as it acknowledged their contribution to the national crisis.

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<sup>12</sup> First Crisis Board meeting, Minutes, 19 April 2016.

<sup>13</sup> Country level RM initiatives with the private sector are discussed in Chapter 2.9 “Communications and Resource Mobilization”.

**There were only few Crisis Management Support Team (CMST) meetings<sup>14</sup>.** Some of the CMST functions of “programme, operations and advocacy support to the CO”<sup>15</sup> were absorbed by the CB, others appear to have been addressed by the First Responders from RBLAC and CRU who were deployed to Ecuador.

**First Responders (FR) were deployed within the first few days:** a Programme Advisor from RBLAC, a Programme Specialist from CRU, an Operations Manager and a Communications Specialist from other COs in the region. Together, they supported the CO in shaping the initial response, defining strategic and programmatic priorities and sequencing the activities in the most efficient way. They galvanized the CO shift to an “emergency response” mode, were part of the country Response Team, designed CERF and Flash Appeals, participated in interagency coordination and coordinated the Early Recovery sector. They negotiated with the Government on key priorities and on the support that UNDP could provide, designed the communications campaign, provided technical knowledge on Fast Track measures to the Operations team and set up the operational side of the emergency response and early recovery.

**The SURGE Planning Team was deployed on the 28<sup>th</sup> of April for one week,** and it integrated the four First Responders. It included also a Recovery Advisor with PDNA expertise and the Team leader with aid management expertise. The SURGE Planning Team assessed the preparedness, operational and programmatic capacity of the CO as well as the interagency coordination environment; it worked with the CO to articulate the vision that would guide UNDP response in four components: national leadership, emergency response, reconstruction and recovery, productive reactivation. The SURGE Plan estimated the response budget on USD 80 millions in two years, which would require the deployment of 26 short-term positions over three months to strengthen the CO capacity. These positions addressed different aspects of the response: PDNA, advisory services to the Government, programme management, project implementation, enabling functions and operations. The total budget amounts to USD 577,000. The SURGE Plan also included a risk analysis and a communications plan.

**In August 2016, upon request of the Crisis Board a SURGE Plan follow-up mission took place.** The mission assessed the results of the SURGE support extended to the CO and the initial achievements such as the finalization of the PDNA, the coordination of the ER sector, resource mobilization results and the opening of a field office. The mission recommended the extension of SURGE support and of some SURGE positions to 6 months, to provide senior advisory support to the Government, increase ER support at national and field level, continue to have expertise in the required programmatic and operational areas.

## *Findings*

**The Crisis Board, led by the Regional Director, supported the CO as needed in mobilizing the corporate response, but there was a weaker follow-up on resource mobilization.** The initial funds allocated were critical in kick-starting the response and showing UNDP’s potential and capacities. The CO did not develop, and the CB did not demand a resource mobilization strategy or action plan (RMAP). According to the SOPs, for Level 2 crises RB/CO with support from BERA and CRU should develop the RMAP and the Crisis Board should review its progress. The SOPs also assign to BERA, in collaboration with the RB, the leadership “on advocacy and outreach towards donors in NY, Geneva and relevant Capitals and support with resource mobilisation efforts for the Recovery Programme”.<sup>16</sup> Given the peculiar RM context of Ecuador, the CB could have facilitated more support to the CO, if not at the beginning when the situation was promising, at least when the expected funding from International Financial Institutions (IFIs) fell through. According to SOPs, the RB is responsible for

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<sup>14</sup> Informants interviewed could not recall exact information about the CMST meetings, the author was not able to access any minutes or other documentation.

<sup>15</sup> Corporate SOPs for Immediate Crisis Response, September 2017.

<sup>16</sup> Corporate SOPs for Immediate Crisis Response, Chapter 5.2 – Resource Mobilization.

supporting CO's resource mobilisation efforts, with inputs as needed from BERA, CRU and BPPS. The CB is expected to review regularly progress on the RMAP.

**Another responsibility of the CB that was only partially fulfilled was to provide leadership on “gender considerations”.**<sup>17</sup> The CB should have demanded more accountability to the CO on the gender-responsiveness of its programmatic activities. The SOPs state that “each mandatory CB will have a standing agenda item addressing gender”; however, this happened only in one CB meeting in the case of Ecuador. In that meeting, the Bureau for Policy and Programme Support (BPPS) insisted on UNDP's commitments on gender – similarly stated in the SURGE Plan - but there is no recorded follow-up on the matter by the CB. The CMST could also ensure that gender commitments are implemented, with technical support from BPPS and/or Regional Gender specialists.

**In the case of Ecuador there wasn't a sustained Crisis Management Support Team (CMST) – only a few meetings have taken place. The Ecuador crisis was the first time the Crisis SOPs were applied in their final version, and therefore the first time CMSTs took place. A more regular CMST could have helped in addressing some of the issues highlighted earlier on programmatic support to the response and on corporate RM support.** According to SOPs and related Terms of Reference, for a Level 2 crisis the CMST coordinator is the RB Advisor, and the alternate is the CRU Crisis Coordinator; the fact that the RB Advisor and the CRU specialist for LAC were both deployed to Ecuador as First Responders has contributed to the initial irregularity of the CMST. In following crises, UNDP found a better balance between CB and CMST meetings, using the latter for implementation of CB decisions and follow-up on CO requests, as per ToRs.

**Coordination between different levels of the organization worked reasonably well, however some informants have highlighted how current mechanisms for the substantive involvement and participation of HQ/RH programmes in crisis response seem not completely effective.** In particular, it emerges from interviews that a more substantive involvement of recovery and gender expertise would have benefited the quality of the Ecuador response. Some practical issues were indicated:

- CRU, RBLAC or the CO could have shared information more widely, including: documents and data on the crisis, for technical overview and feedback (for example, ToRs of potential SURGE deployees, strategic documents on the response, analysis and so on). A wider circulation however can only be effective if matched by a swift turnaround with comments and suggestions, as the pace of emergency response is much faster. Technical specialists and advisors are also encouraged to continue to actively seek information and engage with the CO, RBLAC or CRU as needed.
- The participation of BPPS (Recovery) was limited to the PDNA Advisor who was part of the SURGE team, and whose Terms of Reference focused only on the PDNA. From the information collected, there has been no further involvement of BPPS (Recovery) in the crisis response
- BPPS lacks budget for field missions. After UNDP's restructuring, it has not been assigned funds for this type of country support missions; missions can only take place if funded by other sources, such as CRU or the CO. This affects BPPS staff both in HQ and in the Regional Hub. In following crises BPPS staff have participated as part of the First Responders or SURGE Planning teams.

**These elements point towards a more substantive difficulty on the programmatic support to crisis response by different parts of the organization.** Several informants from different departments have indicated the need for greater coordination among different parts of UNDP and a greater participation of technical teams. From the interviews held, it appears this issue goes beyond the case of Ecuador, and therefore it should be addressed at corporate level.

**Programmatic support could be also useful in helping the CO transforming the initial vision of the SURGE Plan, into a more structured one for the recovery planning.** Some informants highlight how both BPPS and

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<sup>17</sup> Corporate SOPs for Immediate Crisis Response , September 2017.

the Regional Hub can provide support with UNDP's global experience in post-earthquake response and recovery programmes, and with the documentation of successful experiences that can be thus incorporated into UNDP collective knowledge. This technical assistance for the transition to recovery could be included as possible SURGE support in the initial SURGE plan.

**The First Responders deployments were assessed by both parts as very positive:** the CO had an open attitude to receive help and advice and it also provided any possible assistance to the incoming FRs; the FRs themselves had a positive, "can-do" and respectful attitude and integrated well with the Ecuador team. Regular information-sharing meetings organized by the CO Crisis Response Coordinator contributed as well. The FRs were instrumental in switching the CO into "emergency mode" and in helping it to focus and sequence key priorities in the initial chaos of a disaster response. They boosted the capacity of an office that had limited crisis response experience. As such, the deployment of FRs was a successful initiative and should be maintained.

**FRs were absorbed in the SURGE Planning Team, which was helpful as the team did not start from zero but already with a good understanding of the situation.** If this arrangement is maintained in the future, it means that once the SURGE Planning Team deploys, FR functions virtually end to become SURGE planning functions. It follows that the right timing and sequencing in deployments of FRs and SURGE team should be ensured, to avoid gaps or overlaps, and that ToRs for both functions need to be designed accordingly and to be consistent with each other.

**In line with UNDP's commitment on gender, First Responders ToRs should include measurable gender-related responsibilities and deliverables.** Studies demonstrate that crises are not gender-neutral and the different needs and vulnerabilities of each group are exacerbated by the emergency; therefore, a gender-responsive approach is a must for quality programming from the beginning. All FRs should be properly trained on gender in emergencies and early recovery; gender should also be explicitly part of the CRU First Responders training, and gender expertise should be used as a prioritizing factor for deployments.

**The SURGE Planning Team contribution it is also judged very positive by the different stakeholders interviewed;** the Team had a good composition and was well organized, had a good division of roles and was efficiently run. It reported daily to Senior Management and interacted on occasions with the rest of the CO beyond the CRT. According to one team member, it would have been useful to discuss the response with all key CO staff from the beginning – even if not directly involved in the emergency – rather than towards the end as it was the case in Ecuador. This can ensure from the beginning that the entire CO contributes their views, including context, feasibility of ideas and possible obstacles, and can help in reducing the risk of a siloed response.

**The SURGE Plan is a comprehensive document that highlights both the immediate priorities and the medium-term vision for the CO, based on the initial perceptions of expected needs and resources potentially available.** It is considered by the CO a useful tool to focus and define priorities, which also guided decisions on RM and interagency coordination. It established not only the immediate actions but also a medium and longer-term vision that helped management in leading the CO beyond the crisis. The SURGE Plan did not elaborate extensively on ER coordination and on UNDP's role as a cluster lead, and this was in fact one of the weaker parts of UNDP performance.<sup>18</sup>

**Some informants reason that the SURGE Plan is done too early and for this motive it is often too ambitious.** While there is still a need for an immediate plan to operationalize UNDP's vision (therefore SURGE planning should be maintained at the beginning of a crisis response) and to scale up UNDP country office's capacity to respond and start the recovery activities; the situation after a disaster is very dynamic and both needs and resources available might change, therefore a mechanism should exist to adapt the SURGE Plan to possible

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<sup>18</sup> UNDP's sector lead performance is discussed in Chapter 2.8.

changes. UNDP could foresee a review of the SURGE Plan two or three months after the initial formulation (either through a CRU/RB/BPPS joint mission or remotely, depending on the specific needs of each crisis); this review and the resources it requires should be factored in the initial version of the SURGE Plan. The review should include a programmatic analysis of the CO portfolio and crisis response implemented, in order to build upon existing activities to design long-term recovery support, including as necessary the Recovery Framework for the CO or support to national recovery planning that UNDP provides to Governments. The review could also reassess the support required through SURGE deployment, based on how support needs have evolved.

**Other informants reflect instead on the energy and resources the SURGE Plan demands and conclude that it is a tool that needs to be revised, since it's not always implemented in full.** While a revision might be useful, what counts more is not the final result, but the process. Without a mandatory result like the SURGE Plan, in the rush of the emergency and the enormous workload that follows a crisis, it would be very easy to postpone the elaboration of the plan. However, the collaborative reflection and strategic thinking that bring together HQ's experienced emergency staff and a CO who knows well the context and the needs are necessary and non-negotiable elements for a quality performance.

**In hindsight, the Ecuador SURGE Plan turned out very ambitious in terms of resource mobilization compared to the actual resources raised;** however several informants report that at the time of its formulation, projections of contributions from IFIs were realistic. In fact, this discrepancy doesn't seem to have had significant consequences; it could be easily corrected in the future if a review was introduced after some time from the initial formulation.

**Finally, the SURGE follow-up mission that took place in August 2016 was useful to confirm the need for an extended SURGE support and to determine on what areas, as per its ToRs. It could have been more valuable with broader ToRs aimed at providing programmatic support to assist the CO in designing the long-term recovery programme.** In the case of Ecuador, lack of funding did not allow for the participation of a BPPS Specialist. As mentioned earlier, for future crises a follow-up review (either in the form of a mission or as remote support) would be useful and it could include an analysis and review of SURGE support and also a solid programmatic review, to assess UNDP programmes and support if pertinent the development of the recovery framework. In this sense, CMST in close consultation with the CO and concerned Bureau would recommend the participation of technical advisors from BPPS headquarters or from the Regional Hub.

## 2.5 Deployment of experts

### *Main developments*

**Based on the operational and programmatic capacity of the CO and the needs of the response, the SURGE Plan identified six main functions required to boost the CO capacity for an initial period of three months.** These functions were to be performed by a total of 26 positions:

- Post Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA)
- Government Advisor functions
- Programme management
- Project implementation
- Enabling functions including coordination and communications
- Operations

SURGE support was sourced from other COs in the region through detail assignments, the Stand-by Partner MSB, and the ExpRes roster. The total funding requirement for three months was USD 577,000, including approximately USD 100,000 of operational costs.

**Of the 26 positions identified, three were not deployed: the Early Recovery Advisor (Gender Focus), the Productive Reactivation Advisor—both to be assigned to the National Committee for Reconstruction and Productive Reactivation (NCRPR), and the Human Resources Associate, to be stationed at UNDP.** According to the information collected, the Government did not consider the first two necessary.

Key deliverables for the different SURGE deployees were:

- Coordination of the UN system contribution to the PDNA;
- Advisory services to Government, Coordination Ministries and line Ministries on emergency, early recovery and recovery, and support on the development and initial implementation of the national recovery framework, including on social issues;
- Support to the CO in the formulation of UNDP's own recovery strategy and programmes;
- Support to the establishment and management of a sub-office in Manta and coordination and implementation of UNDP response;
- Operational support to the CO in particular on Procurement, Logistics, Finance and ICT;
- Leadership and coordination of the Early Recovery Sector;
- Development and implementation of a communications strategy and plan.

**The SURGE Follow-up mission recommended the extension of 12 positions to:**

- Continue to support advisory services to the Government, the National Committee for Reconstruction and some Ministries, in order to position UNDP as a key actor in the recovery process;
- Increase UNDP's role in Early Recovery Coordination, in view of the planned downscaling of OCHA and the request from the Resident Coordinator to take over some of OCHA's responsibility in the subnational coordination hubs;
- Continue to provide technical expertise on programmes and operations.

Due to the non-deployment of two senior positions budgeted in the SURGE Plan, and to the decision of the CO to invest in local capacity, the extension of 12 positions for further 3 months cost only additional USD 117,000.

**The CO chose to invest in local capacity, particularly in the transition phase out of SURGE, by shortening some international deployments and hiring national staff with the resources saved.** International experts were paired with national ones to facilitate the transfer of knowledge and to invest in national capacity, this increasing sustainability. For example, a national engineer, who took over responsibilities when MSB personnel left, supported one of the MSB deployees.

### *Findings*

**Overall, the views on the effectiveness of the SURGE support are mixed.** The majority of the SURGE support provided—by other COs, by MSB and by several consultants recruited—was successful. The Government advisory support instead did not achieve the expected impact. A key UNDP strategy in the Ecuador response was to offer specialized expertise to the Government on recovery and reconstruction through the secondment of experts to national entities (National Committee for Reconstruction and Productive Reactivation, Coordination Ministries, line Ministries). This would have been a good strategy to influence the national response, and a very potent one if it had been more successful.

**The support provided by SURGE deployees seconded to different Government entities was of limited impact.** On one side, the strong national ownership of the reconstruction and recovery process, the political weight and electoral returns of the Government's ability to face the disaster, the confidence of the authorities on their own capacities and limited openness to external recommendations, made the SURGE deployees almost redundant. In fact, one of them was reassigned after only one month.

Reportedly, some entities did not seem interested in making the best use of the expertise available, they frequently sidelined or excluded SURGE deployees from key meetings and did not share information extensively, thus reducing their opportunities to engage and provide support. Two of the positions initially proposed, the Early Recovery Advisor (Gender Focus) and the Productive Reactivation Advisor were not deployed, as the authorities did not consider them necessary.

On the other side, several informants both in the Government and within UNDP have remarked that a less self-assured attitude from some SURGE deployees, the capacity to establish good personal relations, to read well the national context and to adapt to it, would have likely led to better results. Several informants also consider that some solutions proposed were not tailored to the Ecuadorian context but rather a reproduction of past experiences in other countries. Out of the four positions seconded to the Government, two were evaluated as negative and one as positive with reserves. All other deployments were evaluated as positive, with the exception of one Stand-by Partner deployee who was evaluated negatively.

**To minimize unsuccessful deployments, UNDP should take measures to improve the selection and matching of SURGE deployees with the assignment and context in which they will operate.** First of all, in future crises UNDP should discuss more in-depth what support the authorities require and it should negotiate detailed Terms of Reference adapted to the crisis and clearly indicating the support required and deliverables expected; ToRs can also be reviewed after a while as a crisis situation is highly dynamic and needs might change. Furthermore, the organization should always take a proactive approach and intervene immediately in case of an ineffective deployment, either by shortening a contract or by reassigning the SURGE staff to more suitable tasks.

The majority of the staff interviewed believe there is a shortage of Spanish-speaking experts in UNDP database. In the case of Ecuador, one of the constraining factors was the combination of programmatic expertise and language skills. However, a keyword search for Spanish on the approximately 3000 profiles existing, returns 953 results (around one third of the total), while a sample search for livelihoods and Spanish returns 260 profiles. Evidently, the more specific a desired profile is, the more difficult will be to find a match. To address at least in part this issue, UNDP should review its pool of potential SURGE resources and continue its efforts to grow the roster.<sup>19</sup> Another option (admittedly less easy) is to identify as potential deployees nationals of Spanish –speaking countries (both practitioners and from the academia) or someone from the diaspora community, who would have a better knowledge of the context and possibly better acceptance.

**UNDP should have insisted for the Gender<sup>20</sup> advisor to be deployed, and if not successful in convincing the Government, reassign the Advisor to work in UNDP rather than be seconded to national authorities.** Gender equality is often de-prioritized in emergency response, with the excuse of urgency and prevalence of other needs. Dismissing gender matters on emergency grounds is equally absurd as to say that children's needs will not be addressed at the beginning of a crisis as they are not life threatening. It is UNDP's responsibility to advocate vigorously for a gendered approach in crisis response, early recovery and recovery, to support the authorities and where necessary take the initiative, when a gap is identified.

**Overall, the SURGE support on programme management and project implementation functioned much better than the Government Advisory SURGE support.** The CO, local authorities interviewed, and beneficiaries have all highlighted the relevance and quality of contributions given by experts on a variety of issues like debris management, cash for work, and livelihoods. The quality of the work performed has positioned UNDP well as a reliable partner at all levels; in fact, some projects have been so successful that they are being later replicated both nationally and internationally. In 2017 the Ministry of Productivity chose to use

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<sup>19</sup> UNDP reports that a call for Spanish-speakers will be done in 2017.

<sup>20</sup> The initial proposal for SURGE support was an ER Advisor with gender focus. The CO could have also considered the separation of the 2 positions in an ER Advisor and a Gender Advisor, this however would have required more resources.

the suppliers development methodology for a public policy at national scale, while the “En Marcha” methodology, originally developed for a development setting, adapted in Ecuador to an emergency and early recovery setting, has been replicated by UNDP in Haiti post-hurricane response and is currently implemented in Mexico, after the 2017 earthquake. Some delays in deployments have been reported and gaps between successive deployments; timeliness could be improved in particular between successive incumbents of the same functions, by ensuring a short overlap to allow for a proper handover.

**SURGE support from Stand-by Partner arrived relatively quickly (within 11 days from the earthquake) and the CO deems the support provided generally useful and effective.** One of the deployments was extended for further three months. In another case the person deployed was not effective in their functions, and UNDP provided feedback to the Stand-by Partner. Stand-by partners’ deployees gave technically relevant and sound contributions; they helped in positioning UNDP as a reliable actor and the key partner on debris management in rural areas, both with the national and decentralized authorities, and with the population.

There are some down sides on relying on rosters, including stand-by partners rosters, mainly that experts might not be available when needed if they are engaged somewhere else. Also, on specific subjects (for example debris management), the number of public sector experts is very limited, and private sector experts are more expensive than standard UNDP rates. If UNDP wants to position itself globally on some of its signature products, for example as the go-to organization for debris management in an emergency, it should consider hiring full-time experts who are global authorities on the chosen subject and who develop knowledge through practice, studies and publications. If funding limitations would not allow hiring full-time experts, then UNDP should consider sourcing experts from the private sector (accepting the higher cost this entails) for short-term needs if there are no comparable options in the public sector.

**The SURGE mechanism has shown its flexibility with the SURGE review mission, which highlighted further support needs and recommended the extension of twelve positions for variable lengths of time.** The resources saved from initial deployments and additional USD 100,000 invested by the organization allowed for the extension until the last quarter of the year.

**The SURGE support phase finished between December 2016 and January 2017 when the last deployments ended.** The transition back to “normal business” happened naturally with the end of deployments. Once the SURGE phase was concluded, only a few positions were retained, according to the CO: the Disaster Risk Reduction position and two positions for the “En Marcha” and “Creciendo con Su Negocio” projects. The CO has partially changed its programmatic structure, by creating a new Unit called Inclusive Economic Development and Risk Management, an evolution and merging of the former Crisis Response and Local Development Units.

Two final observations on the deployments: minor tensions were reported with a few individual deployments, but generally the CO was able to absorb well the SURGE wave. National staff interviewed has expressed on occasion the need for more information sharing; the issue was solved by monthly information sessions led by the CO Crisis Response Coordinator during the all-staff meeting.

## 2.6 Programmatic response

### *Main developments*

**At the time of the earthquake, the CO programme was organized in the following thematic areas:**

- Social Development and Governance
- Environment and Energy
- Territorial development.

The main entry points for the crisis response and subsequent recovery were the programmes on Disaster Risk Reduction, Small Grants, Supply Providers and Territorial Development. All of these would be involved to different extent in the response.<sup>21</sup>

**UNDP's programmatic vision as described in the SURGE Plan is articulated in two phases: emergency and early recovery, and reconstruction and recovery.** In the first phase, UNDP planned to scale up its pilot projects addressing debris management, livelihoods stabilization and emergency employment, while in the medium-long term recovery phase it would work on governance, disaster risk management and developing recovery capacity. Key principles to guide UNDP's programmatic action include "building back better", addressing vulnerabilities and social exclusion, gender equality, environmental sustainability, risk-informed decision making, partnership, national leadership, among others.

UNDP opted for a three-track approach aimed at progressing from livelihoods stabilization (emergency employment and cash for work, rehabilitation of community infrastructure and reestablishing employment for small and micro businesses), to economic recovery (via conditional cash transfer, development of inclusive markets, and job placement and productive capacity building), to economic reintegration and inclusive growth (via capacity building and governance).

**Livelihood recovery activities took place through the adaptation of existing methodologies to the emergency context** ("En Marcha!"<sup>22</sup> methodology, already used in Haiti and Mexico, as well as in Quito before the crisis, and "Creciendo con Su Negocio"<sup>23</sup> methodology, an adaptation of the Suppliers Development Programme). UNDP also supported local governments and communities in strengthening their capacities and resilience through the development of local risk management and contingency plans. Activities took place both in Manabí and Esmeralda regions, focusing more on Manabí province and approximately on half of the Cantons within the province.

**UNDP did not make major adjustments to its existing programmes.** There were minor modifications to the Small Grants Programme on existing activities in the areas affected by the earthquake, and some additional initiatives including a competition on tourism made possible through external cash and in-kind donations (for a total amount of approximately USD 266,000). A pre-existing ECHO-funded project was adapted to include earthquake affected areas without reprogramming resources; UNDP's component of the project (still ongoing) aims at providing technical support to the Humanitarian Country Team, to national authorities on early recovery and on risk management, developing local recovery strategies for the affected provinces, and supporting livelihoods.

**Two weeks after the disaster, a pilot project was launched in Las Gilces community, including several of the components highlighted above (debris management, cash for work, rehabilitation of community infrastructure and livelihoods recovery).** The pilot was the first project that UNDP started and it helped showcasing UNDP's capacity – in fact the CO considers it the source of several other initiatives, funded thanks to the results achieved in Las Gilces.

**SURGE support was essential in designing and implementing UNDP's programmes:** for example, Stand-by partners and other SURGE staff implemented debris management and Cash for Work activities; the Recovery Programme Advisor adapted the En Marcha methodology that was successfully used for livelihoods recovery.

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<sup>21</sup> The programmatic response will be discussed in Chapter 2.6.

<sup>22</sup> In motion!

<sup>23</sup> Growing with Your Business.

**The use of CRPs was quite limited (mostly to the Debris Management CRP), according to the informants interviewed.** Some people did not find them useful because part of them was not in Spanish; others because they are more oriented to low-income contexts and were less apt for a middle-income country like Ecuador.

**The CO didn't develop a new recovery framework in substitution to the one included in the SURGE Plan** (which included activities for 2 years and planned USD 80 millions); it contributed instead to the design of the livelihoods component of the national recovery strategy.

### *Findings*

**UNDP's programmes were pertinent as they were coherent with national priorities, addressed the needs identified during assessments and some gaps in the existing response (particularly in rural areas and with the most vulnerable population); leveraged UNDP's expertise and added value.** While the relevance of UNDP's intervention is not under question, some informants have expressed reservations on the extent of their coverage and the geographic target. The Government organized the response by assigning Ministries to coordinate all actions in each geographic area; it was also assertive in indicating to the international community where support was needed and where it was not. The majority of UNDP's activities took place in Manabí province, and only into some cantons within the province. According to the CO, geographic targeting was based on criteria such as: areas where UNDP was already working or had relations in place with local authorities; indications of priority (or exclusion) from the national government; absence of other actors and gaps in the response; possibility to work at different levels (community, parish, municipality and so on). In hindsight, the CO itself recognizes that it could have given more attention to Esmeraldas province.

With more resources, more areas would have been covered. Nevertheless, even if not able to intervene directly, UNDP still has the responsibility to advocate with authorities, donors and partners to address critical gaps. The existing good relationship with the Government and access to its highest levels gave UNDP better opportunities for advocacy than other ER actors. Another strategy that could have been used to expand ER interventions is to leverage resources of other sectors, by taking a cross-cluster approach to livelihoods recovery.

**UNDP's programmatic impact could be improved by a systematic design of interventions as mutually reinforcing, in particular those that aim at building/strengthening resilience.** Some of the activities implemented effectively build on each other, for example the pilot project in Las Gilces, which addresses all aspects of early recovery from different angles. In other projects instead, the different components seem unrelated: for example, in one of the ECHO-funded projects UNDP's results include recovery activities for 40 families in rural communities in Riochico, and the elaboration of two strategies for livelihoods recovery for Esmeraldas and Manabí provinces. These two aspects are parallel and do not contribute to each other. Some of the activities conducted with local authorities and communities contribute to resilience strengthening, however a contingency plan alone is not sufficient to build resilience. In addition, the activities (livelihoods recovery, institutional strengthening, community risk management strengthening) could all contribute to resilience, but they were not integrated to this effect. For example, micro-entrepreneurs or associations supported by the livelihood recovery projects were not necessarily members of the communities where risk management plans were developed. By integrating these different interventions, the impact on resilience could be larger. According to the CO, this is linked to the donor requirement of a consortium project and needs being identified separately and in advance by the implementing organizations, which led to parallel interventions.

**In crises, it is worth continuously reflecting on the right balance between direct assistance to the population and addressing unmet needs—which remains necessary—and the impact that UNDP can achieve by influencing the Government in making policy changes that can affect hundreds of thousands of people.** Ecuador CO worked at both levels, by implementing debris management and livelihood recovery activities that

addressed a few thousand people, and by seconding SURGE resources to the Government and supporting the design of the national Reconstruction and Recovery Plan. In the case of SURGE employees seconded to the Government, the experience was not successful in Ecuador, but the strategy in itself could be more successful in another context and should be further explored. Programmatic activities were not scaled up to a major extent, and it is not possible at the moment to estimate the total number of people that have benefitted from UNDP's interventions.<sup>24</sup> It is therefore not possible to conduct a cost opportunity analysis but it is important to keep in mind that UNDP has intangible strengths – for example access and capacity to influence the Government – that other organizations do not have to the same extent; UNDP should always reflect on how to employ its resources for maximum impact, and if necessary delegate some activities to other partners.

**Gender issues were not addressed systematically and therefore results could have been better with a more intentional approach.** There was not a gender analysis in the assessments, including in the PDNA, where some gender aspects are touched but there is not a gender analysis of the impact of the earthquake in each sector; not all projects took into consideration the different impact on women and men and how UNDP's interventions could contribute to reduce gender inequality.

Some of UNDP's projects ensured the inclusion of a significant percentage of women as beneficiaries, but this is a simplistic measure if it is the only one and a more sophisticated approach is expected from UNDP. Reducing gender inequality requires addressing specific vulnerabilities and taking gender-responsive or gender-transformative action.<sup>25</sup> Programmes and activities that do not deliberately pursue a gender-transformative agenda are likely to be gender-blind and therefore perpetuate existing inequalities, which are worsened by crises and disasters. All the CRPs include useful guidance on gender in programmatic activities.

Some initiatives in UNDP's programme, like childcare for mothers during the debris management phase, did address practical needs and contributed to challenging gender stereotypes by allowing women to work in a non-traditional area. Other initiatives like the livelihoods recovery ones could have focused more on gender inequality by including women associations as target beneficiaries of "Creciendo con Su Negocio" methodology even if they didn't cover all the selection criteria; or by prioritizing female micro-entrepreneurs in the "En Marcha!" projects. In fact, one of the "En Marcha!" reports show that the methodology exceedingly benefits women and people with lower education – the most vulnerable groups benefit comparatively more than others. This is a reason to prioritize these groups as beneficiaries, including women, in future applications of the methodology.

The "Livelihoods and social protection emergency interventions in rural communities" project funded by ECHO is more systematic and partially addresses gender issues in each of its components. However, some of them simply include a training on gender or gender-based violence, which is not a comprehensive approach to gender inequality.

**During the WHS, UNDP reaffirmed its commitment to allocate 15% of resources to gender equality and women's empowerment.** This commitment is included in the Corporate SOPs for crisis response and it is repeated in the Ecuador SURGE Plan. It was not possible to assess if the 15% threshold was reached, but there was no evidence of an intentional and systematic pursuing of the target. In fact, several staff interviewed including in the CO reflect that more could have been done for gender equality and women's empowerment.

**The three-track approach adopted by UNDP in its programmes, articulated in livelihoods stabilization, economic recovery and economic reintegration and inclusive growth, links early recovery interventions with longer-term recovery.** An example of this connection is in the adoption of national and subnational entities (namely the Ministry of Productivity and the Esmeraldas Local Government) of livelihoods recovery

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<sup>24</sup> The estimation is not possible in part because some projects are still active, in part because data reported is not comparable or incomplete.

<sup>25</sup> As opposed to gender-blind action that perpetuates inequality and often worsens it.

methodologies in their public policies and operational development plans. Another example are the efforts towards institutional strengthening of local authorities, like in the ECHO-funded project.

The commitments of the May 2016 World Humanitarian Summit on how to bridge the humanitarian/development divide would have been a good input to articulate the link between ER and recovery in the Ecuador response; however, no discussion took place in the country among partners or donors on this subject. In addition to partners being very busy with the earthquake response and therefore not focusing on external events, it is also likely that in the first few months after the earthquake, WHS commitments were still too generic and required more structure to be applicable to actual crises. In fact, the “New Way of Working” was only articulated in the first months of 2017.

**In the months object of the AAR, the CO did not elaborate a formal recovery framework, and the one outlined in the SURGE Plan became infeasible when the prospective funds from IFIs were not assigned to UNDP.** The Crisis SOPs mention the development of a recovery framework for the post-crisis period and potential corporate support available after the end of the SURGE phase. They are not very detailed on how this support can take place; certainly, this is an opportunity for the involvement of technical specialists from BPPS. In fact, some of the limits to BPPS involvement indicated earlier in the report (linked to BPPS lack of own resources), could be overcome by articulating BPPS technical support in the SOPs in this phase of recovery framework formulation, and providing it with the resources for this phase. UNDP is the mandated agency for recovery and has exceptional knowledge and expertise around the world that can be leveraged on recovery. The links between the SURGE phase and longer-term recovery should be developed further in the SOPs and also be further discussed among the mandated departments in UNDP.

**The CO, during the period object of this Review, addressed five of the six areas of support to Governments on recovery planning,<sup>26</sup> to various extents.** It supported the National Committee for Reconstruction and Recovery by seconding an Advisor; it contributed to the hybrid PDNA/DALA assessment that took place and had also supported a training on PDNA in the months before the earthquake; it contributed to national recovery planning by closely assisting the authorities in developing the chapter on productive reactivation; it supported local authorities in developing livelihood recovery strategies for both affected provinces, as well as including disaster risk management in local operational plans and developing community and local governments contingency plans; it contributed to “Building back better” through the development of updated construction norms through one of its projects.

**The Ecuador experience represents an interesting case of innovation and adaptation of existing livelihood programming methodologies (En Marcha! and Creciendo con Su Negocio) to an emergency context, fostered by the fruitful collaboration between the CO and SURGE support.** The packages developed are easily replicable and have in fact been replicated recently in other emergency contexts like Haiti and Mexico. With the opportune adaptations (including addressing the gender dimension), they should be included in UNDP’s Crisis Response Packages as possible tools for livelihoods recovery. As CRPs are more oriented to the immediate response and early recovery phases, CRU and BPPS could consider how to integrate these methodologies in CRPs or as different products in UNDP’s collection of tools. UNDP should also reflect on how these methodologies could be applied to scale, rather than as direct but circumscribed interventions.

**The sustainability of programmatic interventions varied.** Some of them included a transfer of knowledge and methodology to local authorities and national Ministries, including the Ministry of Agriculture and the Ministry of Productivity. In fact, in 2017 the Ministry of Productivity chose to use the suppliers development

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<sup>26</sup> The six areas of support to Governments on Recovery Planning and Coordination, are: Institutional Arrangements for Recovery, Post Disaster Needs Assessments, Recovery Planning, Managing Recovery, Building Back Better and Managing Residual Risks, Resource Mobilization.

UNDP, *Guidance Note on National Post-Disaster Recovery Planning and Coordination*, (2017).

methodology (Creciendo con su Negocio) for a public policy at national scale. Conversely, the “En Marcha!” methodology has only been partially transferred, according to the SURGE Advisor who implemented it because for its effectiveness, a strict quality control is necessary and a complete transfer of the methodology without supervision bears a high risk of failure. Indeed, some of the informants interviewed at subnational level highlighted the need to transfer the methodology and tools for sustainability.

## 2.7 Operational response

### *Main developments*

**The Ecuador CO Operations unit at the time of the earthquake** was led by an Operations Analyst, supported by<sup>27</sup> a Technical Assistant, one staff for Human Resources,<sup>28</sup> two Procurement and one Finance staff (while another Finance staff was on administrative leave), one ICT and one Admin Assistant. The CO did not have sub-offices and operated mostly from Quito, with one project staff based in one of the areas affected by the earthquake, Esmeraldas.

**In 2016, the CO was moderately prepared to face an emergency from an operational point of view.** As part of the preparedness for a potential eruption of Cotopaxi volcano, the CO had developed a Business Continuity Plan (BCP)<sup>29</sup> that was activated and allowed UNDP and the Resident Coordinator Office to function from the alternate site (at OIM offices) in the first hours and days until the UN building safety was confirmed.

**The majority of the CO Operations staff had not previously been exposed to emergencies and had limited (if any) knowledge of Fast Track Procedures (FTPs).** In the course of 2016, FTP policies on engagement with NGOs, human resources and procurement were mainstreamed, and were directly applied in the case of Ecuador. They were immediately activated with the support of RBLAC and the CO was able to create a project in Atlas within 12 hours, which facilitated subsequent planning and implementation activities. The CO took advantage of other FTP provisions, for example the possibility of direct project implementation, direct recruitment of up to 5 TAs, the increase in purchase authorization limits.

At the time of the Ecuador crisis response an FTP was introduced: the “Use of NGOs as responsible parties agreement” procedures. Although it was known by the Operations staff, once introduced it was immediately applied. Particularly useful was the simplified capacity assessment, which speeds up the process to engage NGOs. The tools have been used for example with the NGO in charge of debris management in Manabí pilot project; this first experience has been used to develop tools and checklists to contract more NGOs for the Cash for Work projects.

**A few days after the disaster a First Responder (Procurement Specialist) was deployed** and he was instrumental in speeding up procurement operations for goods and services, particularly at the beginning of the crisis. He was very knowledgeable and the Operations Team in country deemed his support very valuable.

Once the SURGE Planning Team arrived, they agreed with the CO what additional Operations staff would be required. Given the expected increase in activities, and the operational capacity analysis conducted, the SURGE Plan suggested:

- Detailed assignment: NOA Procurement Manager for 3 months; NOA Finance Associate for one month, HR Associate for 3-6 months

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<sup>27</sup> Not including Service Contracts.

<sup>28</sup> HR unit is supervised by the DRR.

<sup>29</sup> The BCP was not made available therefore it is not analyzed in the present AAR.

- New recruitments: Logistics NOA for 3 months; Finance Associate G7 for 3 months, IT Associate G4 for 3 months.

In addition, the Procurement Manager position was filled with two assignments of three months from other COs in the region; two Logistics Officers were recruited for three months each, a Finance Manager detail assignment took place for one month, a Finance Associate and an IT Associate were recruited for three month each. The only position not deployed was the HR associate as the CO considered it was not necessary. The SURGE follow up mission recommended extending the Operations positions for further three month. The CO capacity was further strengthened with on-the-job trainings for the Manta sub-office Operations staff.

**UNDP opened a project office in Manta, between the 23<sup>rd</sup> May 2016<sup>30</sup> and the 31<sup>st</sup> August 2017 to facilitate the implementation of response activities and coordinate with the Government,** which established its headquarters for the crisis response in Portoviejo. UNDP joined WFP and several other UN agencies in opening the office in Manta. The choice fell on a local hotel, efficient choice because the hotel already had in place facilities and services that otherwise would have had to be contracted separately (security, internet, electricity). This saved time and energy from the operations unit that could focus on other activities.

### *Findings*

**The CO/Operations team preparedness and training on emergencies was limited.** While recognizing that the team was quick in learning and applying FTPs and other tools, a higher level of preparedness would have been beneficial.

**Crisis response trainings for COs should increase the space dedicated to Operations:** in the 2017 week-long LAC Crisis Preparedness Workshop for example, there is limited time dedicated to the operations side of preparedness and response (one 45-minutes session on BCP, one session on Minimum Preparedness Actions and BCP, one session on Advanced preparedness and an exercise on CO preparedness). More focus on the operational component of the crisis response – with support from BMS - is recommended, as well as the implementation and regular update of Minimum Preparedness Actions.

**The use of Crisis Response Packages (CRPs) was limited.** They include operational tools like ToRs, checklists, procurement lists and so on; only two First Responders reported using them for operational purposes. In addition, they are in English and sometimes they had to be translated to Spanish, making them less suited for rapid utilization.

**Corporate support was rapid and effective in starting the crisis response.** RBLAC activated the Fact Track Procedures following a phone call and the system was amended afterwards. As the CO did not have access to electricity and Internet after the earthquake, swift action from the Regional Bureau was essential. There were no Operations deployments from BMS, RBLAC or the Regional Hub but the CO recognizes their remote support and continuous availability. RBLAC also provided advice on the technical issues for cash operations in the Cash for Work projects.

**The CO assessed as valuable the support received from both First Responders and SURGE staff on procurement, logistics, ICTs.** Deployments within the Operations team were positive and did not experience frictions. Key informants have highlighted that additional Operations staff should have the required delegation/authorizations to perform as needed. In the case of Ecuador, for some time only one person had buyer access to Atlas. There should be the possibility to assign exceptional access status to temporary for a better distribution of work.

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<sup>30</sup> Staff and SURGE were deployed to the affected area well before the 23<sup>rd</sup> of May when the Manta office opened.

The Finance Unit was reportedly slower than expected. This is due in part to the absence of one staff (on administrative leave) and in part to the increased amount of work brought in by the emergency. The CO was in fact already understaffed with having one staff on administrative leave; in hindsight, it would have been useful to have one extra SURGE finance staff or extend the time of the one on detail assignment.

Both in the Manta office and in CO, the large amount of incoming SURGE personnel increased significantly the demands on ICT, in terms of equipment and service provision, causing delays. The CO was limited to one ICT officer and therefore requested and obtained additional ICT SURGE; the ensuing deployment solved the situation.

**Opening a field office in Manta was a successful strategic decision.** Several staff and SURGE positions were deployed to Manta, close to the national coordination of the response. From a coordination and programmatic point of view, it was an excellent decision as it enabled coordination with the authorities at the highest level on the ground and not only in Quito. From the operational point of view it was also very positive to join WFP and others in opening the office in a local hotel. Some minor logistics constraints were reported but according to the CO, were quickly resolved.

**All informants interviewed consider exigency measures<sup>31</sup> useful and effective.** In particular, the ones doubling authorization/delegation levels for procurement and finance, as they contribute to faster delivery. The “Use of NGOs as responsible parties agreement” enabled faster assessments of partners’ capacity and was particularly relevant for the Cash for Work programmes, as they were the first to be implemented. The CO also used LTAs for consultancies, which included a number of preselected consultants or companies that can be immediately engaged, saving 15 days of vacancy advertisement.

Several informants have indicated possible improvements to consider, including reducing procurement authorization turnaround time from HQ/RSC—ACP/RACP, increasing delegations of authority at different thresholds depending on the scale of the crisis, increasing the number of TAs that can be directly recruited. These and other Fast Track measures have been mainstreamed into relevant policies and processes for faster action. Since 2016, they are now available to all COs in crisis. Some require authorization from the respective RB. One measure that remains to be considered is an analysis of the added value of the documentation required before contracting a vendor or a partner, balancing rapidity of implementation with due diligence and accountability.

**Some of these issues highlight a conundrum often experienced in crises: the elusive balance between speed of action and adequate controls.** In the case of Operations, normal controls might require too much time and slow down the implementation of activities. Due diligence and risk mitigation measures must be taken to guarantee the correct use of resources. Nevertheless, in an emergency, fast action is essential—especially at the beginning—to position an organization as effective and dependable in the eyes of the population, other organizations, government and donors. This does have an impact on its reputation and to a certain extent on resource mobilization opportunities. In trying to find the right balance between flexibility and risk mitigation, organizations working in emergencies should lean towards a more risk-tolerant approach. Investing more on preparedness measures to identify and pre-qualify vendors and partners is part of the minimum preparedness actions a CO could undertake to reduce risks.

**There were a few operational bottlenecks.** Among these: slow turnaround in finance and initially in ICT, and temporarily a single Atlas buyer. The preparations done in view of the expected IADB project were time-consuming. Since the resources in the end were not awarded to UNDP, some informants considered these preparations as a waste of time. However, in emergencies not everything goes as planned and management

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<sup>31</sup> It should be noted that FTPs have been mainstreamed since then therefore some of the issues highlighted have already been addressed by the organization.

can use a no-regrets approach, accepting that certain actions (like preparedness, deployments or similar) are undertaken based on the best information available at the time of the decision.

On the positive side, the crisis was an opportunity to review standard procedures and to improve them. These improvements are maintained to this day, according to Operations staff in the CO: the procurement process was reviewed with a 20% saving on time needed, and the Register of Processes and Contracts was also improved. It would also be useful to develop tools to continue monitoring operational improvements after the end of the crisis, to verify if they are retained in the CO practice.

## 2.8 Interagency coordination and UNDP engagement with the country earthquake response

### *Main developments*

**UNDP is a member of the Humanitarian Country Team (HCT) since its constitution in Ecuador in 2013.** It participated in the interagency preparedness process for the Cotopaxi volcano in 2015 and for El Niño in 2016. In its “Lessons Learned” exercise, the HCT recognizes that, although preparedness was not complete, the collaboration it generated was instrumental for coordination and collaboration in certain sectors during the earthquake response.

**Within the humanitarian community, UNDP experienced widespread resistance on the importance of early recovery and on the criticality of its proposed interventions at the beginning of the crisis— including from the Humanitarian Coordinator (HC).** More traditional sectors were given priority over Early Recovery; as a consequence, potential CERF funding was reduced, and UNDP chose to withdraw from CERF. The MIRA was a slow and late process, to which UNDP states no ER sector member was invited, it consolidated information from multiple assessments mostly focusing on agency mandates; comprehensive information on early recovery was not included, although debris management, rehabilitation of community infrastructure and livelihoods recovery are mentioned as priorities. Agencies interviewed disagree on whose responsibility it is to ensure the thoroughness of the MIRA assessment, but the end result is a lack of ER information and analysis in the MIRA. A general lack of coordination in this phase reduced UNDP’s capacity to mainstream ER in other assessments, however it appears that UNDP itself did not engage substantively with other sectors to this effect, reportedly for lack of resources.

**The Flash Appeal recognizes ER as one of the key needs, certainly thanks to UNDP’s advocacy.** It has two strategic objectives, the first one including the traditional humanitarian sectors, and the second one focusing on early recovery and livelihood restoration. The ER sector identified three main strategies to target 100,000 people (out of a total 350,000 for the Appeal): emergency debris removal; rehabilitation of community infrastructure and emergency employment for livelihoods stabilization; assistance to women and men living with disability and the elderly, and attention to host community. The first two strategies were led by UNDP, the third one by IOM. The limited priority given to early recovery and recovery is reflected on the very few cases of integration of early recovery in the other sectors (only shelter and camp coordination and management). The same HCT recognizes that there was a lack of connection between the initial response and the recovery and reconstruction process.

**From the beginning of the crisis, UNDP was the sector<sup>32</sup> lead for Early Recovery at national level and in Manta;** with rotation to the other two subnational coordination hubs (Pedernales and Esmeraldas). UNDP experienced multiple changes of Sector Coordinator, and for most of the time, it was someone external that had less knowledge of the national context and did not have an established network in country.

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<sup>32</sup> In Ecuador, there were not Clusters but Sectors.

**When the Government requested international assistance, the UN immediately provided support through UNDAC and in-country. UNDP had already established a very good relationship with national authorities, which was maintained throughout the response and even strengthened.** This is proved by the high-level access UNDP was always granted and the request for an Advisor to the Vice-President. Nevertheless, national authorities maintained a strong sovereign stance—at least in part due to the national elections planned for 2017—leaving a limited margin of influence to external entities and SURGE deployees as discussed in Chapter 2.5.

**UNDP's strategic approach was to support the country leadership and the National Committee for Reconstruction, as well as key Ministries, through advisory services.** In the context of a strong and capable Government, if successful this is the best strategy as it reinforces national systems, supports ownership and sustainability. Unfortunately, UNDP was not able to capitalize on this opportunity through its SURGE deployees,<sup>33</sup> but relations with the Government remained very good. UNDP supported the Government on a variety of issues including the assessment/PDNA and the design of the reconstruction and recovery plan and of some interventions and provided technical assistance to several entities. According to CO staff interviewed, UNDP's technical support made the national plan more oriented towards ER and recovery than it initially was.

**On the other side, Government stakeholders have expressed some concerns,** including: lack of coordination and competition among UN agencies; lack of coordination with Ministries on individual projects; lack of information and feedback to the authorities on the funds received through the Flash Appeal and their use; and the need for UNDP to focus efforts more directly towards sectorial strategies identified by the authorities.

**At subnational level, UNDP had worked with local administration even before the earthquake and was able to leverage the preexisting relations to continue support to authorities in the crisis response.** UNDP strengthened the institutional capacities of the National Decentralized Risk Management System, through an existing preparedness project funded by ECHO; ensured the participation of local authorities in the selection of project beneficiaries; strengthened local capacities by training subnational officers on livelihood recovery, provided technical support on local reconstruction and rehabilitation projects.

**UNDP had organized a training on PDNA in the months before the earthquake and the National Secretariat for Planning and Development (SENPLADES) had started an adaptation of the methodology to the Ecuadorian context; the Government, however, accepted an offer from the Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean (ECLAC) to conduct instead a Damage and Loss Assessment (DALA), later asking for a combined assessment methodology.** According to some informants, the UN initially hesitated in offering the PDNA, possibly for lack of knowledge and experience on the matter, which left the space for other options; the Senior PDNA Coordinator was also deployed 11 days after the earthquake. Other informants state that ECLAC intervention was an intentional positioning on the assessment, regardless of possible UN delays. Thanks to HQ-level negotiations, an agreement with ECLAC was reached for a joint exercise, to which UNDP contributed several staff.

UNDP organized all the UN system inputs to the month-long exercise, which resulted in a hybrid assessment, conducted using the two complementary methodologies of PDNA and DALA that were later integrated in the final SENPLADES report. The appraisal of the costs of reconstruction (approximately USD 3.3 billions) corresponded to the estimations initially made by the authorities. The assessment articulates the costs of reconstruction into four main groups (social sectors, productive sectors, infrastructure, others) and in three components (immediate response, losses, reconstruction); it was used as the basis for the “National Plan for recovery, reconstruction and productive reactivation” which in turn is articulated into emergency, reconstruction and productive reactivation.

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<sup>33</sup> See discussion in Chapter 2.5.

## Findings

**While recognizing the evident resistance UNDP encountered, as the global (and therefore national) cluster lead UNDP has a responsibility to advocate for Early Recovery even in adverse conditions. Efforts could have continued to ensure ER was taken into consideration in interagency initiatives.** Indeed, one of the lessons learned from the HCT workshop is to ensure the inclusion of Early Recovery in the needs assessment tools to be used, and the disaggregation by sex and age of the information collected.

Making ER part of the required elements of a quality response could reduce part of the resistance on ER that UNDP has encountered in this and other crises. To this effect, UNDP could consider leading the development – in collaboration with other ER expert organizations and the Global Early Recovery Cluster – of Early Recovery Standards, companions to the Sphere Standards, on the same line of other Sphere Project Companion Standards like the INEE—Education in Emergencies, Child Protection Minimum Standards and others. At the moment, the GCER ensures the integration of ER in other standards as they are reviewed, but there are no ER minimum standards as such.

Ultimately, it is the Humanitarian Coordinator's responsibility to ensure that ER is adequately addressed; an Early Recovery Advisor should have been deployed to provide the required strategic and technical support. Advocacy at corporate level with other agencies could have helped in limiting the resistance encountered in country, which reached its highest point with the discussions on CERF funds and secondarily on the absence of ER sector members from MIRA. In both national and corporate advocacy, UNDP could have taken advantage of the momentum created by the WHS commitment of transcending the humanitarian/development divide to keep early recovery high on the agenda. At corporate level, the organization could have provided more assertive advocacy with other organizations.

**UNDP as sector lead complied with its responsibilities of national coordination, information management, and contribution to humanitarian appeals, but was less effective on others:** there wasn't always a clear separation between UNDP, as agency and UNDP as sector coordinator. There was not a sector-wide assessment on early recovery needs with ensuing plan of action; the ER strategy remained on draft, although it was used as an input to develop the national strategy on reconstruction and recovery. The initial interest of many organizations in the ER sector quickly faded as it became evident that resources were limited. An OCHA mapping of ER actors in the affected areas shows 10 in May, but only 5 in July. It was also reported by multiple informants that some organizations engaged in ER activities without the adequate expertise and had to ask for support to UNDP.

**UNDP complied with its basic responsibilities as lead of the ER sector, but once SURGE support ended, the motivation faded to continue sustaining the small sector and the organization focused more on internal issues.** Informants report that the sector became mainly a forum for information sharing and therefore of limited value. Within UNDP there are diverse views on the effectiveness of the sector, which might have contributed to its weaknesses and to the prevalence of an agency focus. While the sector was admittedly small and not all members were technically strong, as a leader it was UNDP's responsibility to ensure a solid ER work and the maximum coverage possible: UNDP should have taken a more assertive approach on advocating for ER with the Government and other organizations, and on integrating ER into other sectors. If the Early Recovery Advisor (Gender Focus) had been deployed he/she could have been able to build a stronger consensus around ER, to assess the RC/HC on early recovery needs, and to strengthen UNDP's strategic leadership of the sector.

**UNDP's prompt engagement in support to the national and subnational response, the positive results achieved on debris management and livelihoods recovery positioned well the organization with the Government of Ecuador.** Different Government stakeholders interviewed have highlighted that UNDP contributed experienced SURGE staff, alerted the authorities on key gaps and provided useful qualitative

information. Interviewed Local authorities also highlighted UNDP's contribution to the response at their level. Some of the stakeholders have noted that, while UNDP's approach was comprehensive, it was limited to certain areas and was not brought to scale. On its part, UNDP CO recognizes the need to work more in the future on a deeper understanding of early recovery with national authorities. National authorities interviewed have repeatedly noted the superior contribution provided by staff in the CO, revealing how long-term relations and trust are more effective than technical expertise in influencing authorities and positioning the organization.

**The divergences on PDNA in Ecuador are likely to be repeated in other countries unless a political agreement is reached with ECLAC.** The Resident Coordinator or UNDP should have immediately offered the PDNA as part of the standard immediate UN support to the country; this initial hesitation combined with ECLAC's interest in conducting a DALA, resulted in an impasse that required HQ-level negotiations to be solved. Despite the technical training that took place a few months before, the authorities seemed to equate methodologies and focused more on the assessment results. The resulting tensions and delays could be avoided in the future by reaching an agreement on the assessment methodology in LAC, and by further emphasizing the PDNA (or the alternative chosen) as part of the standard international community package of support offered to governments in case of disaster. According to the experts consulted, the technical aspects of the two methodologies are complementary and can be harmonized.

**Despite the setbacks, UNDP was able to mainstream the recovery agenda into the PDNA.** Thanks to the support provided by SURGE, and the advocacy and assistance of UNDP CO, the final report articulates the recovery needs for all sectors. In part, these are closely linked to reconstruction and include the principles of "building back better" but focus less on "soft" components like strengthening capacities, putting systems in place, developing public policies to foster recovery, and generally strengthening governance. A more comprehensive approach to recovery is used instead when discussing productive sectors and the decentralized risk management system. The PDNA does not include a solid gender analysis by sector.

## 2.9 Communications and resource mobilization

### *Main developments*

- **Communications**

Preparedness activities conducted since 2015, albeit not extensive, set the basis for the communications response to the earthquake.

**Immediately after the events a Communications First Responder was deployed** while the Communications Specialist was temporarily assigned to support the Resident Coordinator/Humanitarian Coordinator and the Humanitarian Country Team, in particular with press conferences, donors and media visits and the production of SitReps. Two more Communications experts were deployed between May and October, based on the SURGE Plan and the associated Communications Plan. The SURGE follow-up mission in August also recommended the extension of the Communications Analyst position for 3 more months.

**UNDP developed a very successful communication campaign called "Ecuador Aquí Estoy".** It engaged a Goodwill Ambassador, Juan F. Velasco, Ecuadorian and Latin American celebrities and artists in the campaign and in two concerts, which took place in May in Miami and Quito. Local televisions participated by producing videos and features and retransmitting the concerts; local companies sponsored the events. The campaign also engaged private citizens to donate online or through a bank account in the States (option soon discarded due to the technical difficulties that it presented). The benefits from the concerts were donated to UNDP. The campaign won two Ecuador Effie Awards (Gold award for Public Relations and Silver award for Non-profits).

According to the CO, the exposure, extra publicity and media presence UNDP gained from this campaign and from the association with the Goodwill Ambassador – a famous singer in Ecuador – could be valued in USD 1.4 millions. Communications products received over 2.3 million visits online. Also, UNDP reached many Ecuadorians thanks to the involvement of Independiente del Valle football team, which donated the profits from its matches in the Libertadores Cup.

- **Resource mobilization**

**The CO did not develop a formal resource mobilization strategy or action plan as indicated in the SOPs, nevertheless UNDP mobilized approximately USD 3.95 millions in additional resources for crisis response and early recovery activities:**

| Donor                       | Funds        | Donor                                    | Funds        |
|-----------------------------|--------------|------------------------------------------|--------------|
| UNDP - TRAC 1.1.3           | \$150.000,00 | Government of Japan                      | \$300.000,00 |
| UNDP – CRU                  | \$500.000,00 | Government of Kazakhstan                 | \$50.000,00  |
| Civil society               | \$467.127,00 | Fons Català de Cooperació                | \$25.000,00  |
| Fundación Repsol            | \$100.000,00 | ECHO                                     | \$952.000,00 |
| Concert Ecuador Aquí Estoy  | \$185.115,00 | Football club "Independiente del Valle"  | \$807.875,00 |
| AEI                         | \$100.237,50 | Fondo Italo-Ecuatoriano                  | \$78.062,00  |
| Civil society / livelihoods | \$36.603,53  | Small Grants Programme (various sources) | \$208.100,00 |
| <b>Total</b>                |              | <b>\$3.959.579,03</b>                    |              |

**Upon request from the Government, UNDP offered the use of one of the organization's bank accounts in the United States to facilitate private donations for relief and reconstruction.** The account security measures did not easily allow donations from individuals and after a few days this solution was discarded. It was an innovative approach and in fact a first for UNDP. The organization did not have an established procedure and mechanism to receive contributions directly from the public through the bank account; at the same time the "Donate" button for online contributions had recently been introduced and it still presented some difficulties. Both initiatives indicate UNDP's willingness to test new approaches and technologies and improve them along the way.

**The Central Emergency Response Fund (CERF) released USD 7 millions, prioritizing logistics, shelter, WASH and emergency health.** UNDP was initially involved in CERF discussions and had planned to submit requests for USD 500,000. There was considerable resistance from other humanitarian organizations; UNDP's activities indicated as life-saving or necessary for humanitarian access were not accepted as such, and after further negotiations the amount suggested to UNDP was of USD 250,000. Management considered it insufficient for the activities planned and UNDP withdrew its participation from CERF.

**The Flash Appeal estimated the costs for emergency response and early recovery in USD 72.8 millions, prioritizing "multi-sector life-saving assistance, protection services and immediate livelihood restoration".**<sup>34</sup> Its second strategic objective included debris management, emergency employment and community infrastructure rehabilitation; the ER sector targeted 100,000 people (like most of the other clusters) in the affected areas and required USD 7 millions, around 10% of the total appeal. UNDP presented 3 projects for USD 3,35 millions. In the end, the entire Flash Appeal was funded at approximately 38%, like the ER sector, which received USD 2.63 millions<sup>35</sup> according to the FTS website.

<sup>34</sup> Flash Appeal Ecuador 2016

<sup>35</sup> <https://fts.unocha.org/appeals/522/summary> Website visited on November 13, 2017.

**Initial promising discussions took place with the European Investment Bank (EIB) and the Inter-American Development Bank (IADB)** – respectively for USD 30 millions and USD 35 millions – and led UNDP to develop a proposal for IADB and to start procurement selection procedures, all indicators of the positive result expected. In fact, based on those initial discussions the SURGE Plan indicates a potential recovery programme of USD 80 millions in two years. In the end however, these resources were not awarded to UNDP, but were channeled through Government institutions.

**Resource mobilization was effective with the private sector.** Several companies and foundations approached UNDP for donations, either in funding or in-kind. Among these: the Repsol Foundation, the Independiente del Valle Football Team, The Alliance for Entrepreneurship and Innovation (AEI), and the Vilaseca Group, an Ecuadorian multinational corporation.

### *Findings*

- **Communications**

**Interviewed staff highlighted that more preparedness and trainings on how to manage communications during an emergency would be useful**, not only for the communications team but also for programme officers and managers on how to deal with the media in such occasions.

**First Responders, regional and SURGE support was deemed very useful and the CO team appreciated it.** Minor tensions were reported with one SURGE deployment only. Regional support contributed to the initial coordination and communications efforts, for example by participating in coordination meetings and SitReps managed by OCHA at regional level. This was essential as in the very first days coordination and communication are managed at regional level and a solid UNDP presence in these fora is indispensable to show UNDP's work, and to highlight it in early communications and information sharing products like the SitReps. Visibility in these documents is paramount as they are one of the main sources of information at the beginning of a crisis, when information is still scarce.

**UNDP's was rapid and effective in completing a three-weeks communications campaign, "Ecuador Aquí Estoy" that was very successful and innovative.** The campaign was very popular because it engaged a famous Ecuadorian singer and Goodwill Ambassador, Juan F. Velasco, and many local celebrities, which gave UNDP an exposure that it would have been unable to reach on its own. The concerts and the involvement of the football team Independiente del Valle (IDV) compelled people to participate and donate to UNDP through its online platform. Music and sports events were also a good choice to give a sense of belonging and hope after the earthquake tragedy.

Communications products were rich in audiovisuals and infographics, and started soon to report on achievements, for example the videos showing activities conducted thanks to IDV donations. Some of the products even illustrate the link between humanitarian action, early recovery and longer-term recovery and development, for example the <https://stories.undp.org/building-back-better> website. It is a good approach that helps in educating individual donors on UNDP's work. Immediately after the donations and regularly during the crisis, communications products were used to thank individual donors directly. This is a good strategy to repeatedly engage and to build individual donors' interest and loyalty towards the organization.

**Communications activities were also aimed at traditional donors**, through regular information sharing in SitReps and meetings, and field visits to show UNDP's activities. It does not appear from the information collected that UNDP engaged *substantively* on communications efforts in support or on behalf of the Early Recovery sector, which generally does not feature in UNDP's communications products. As the sector lead,

UNDP should ensure it fulfills its responsibility to advocate for and support the ER sector in its weakest areas (like in this case, resource mobilization).

**UNDP should continue to invest into innovative forms of communication oriented to resource mobilization**, especially in middle-income countries with reduced RM opportunities from traditional donors, and engage private citizens (both in-country and diaspora) as well as the country private sector through its corporate social responsibility.

- **Resource mobilization**

**UNDP mobilized over USD 3.95 million in additional resources.** Compared to the SURGE Plan projections (USD 80 million in two years) the results seem modest. Given the Ecuador context, however, a better measure is the comparison with resources mobilized by similar organizations for the same emergency. According to OCHA FTS,<sup>36</sup> other UN agencies have raised for the 2016 Ecuador earthquake response:

| Organization | Amount as recorded in FTS database |
|--------------|------------------------------------|
| OCHA         | USD 270,000                        |
| UNDP         | USD 2.3 million                    |
| UNICEF       | USD 8.8 million                    |
| IOM          | USD 3.5 million                    |
| WFP          | USD 5.6 million                    |
| WHO/OPS      | USD 1.6 million                    |
| UNHCR        | USD 1.9 million                    |

With this background, and with the caveat that figures in FTS are not precise (as proved by UNDP recorded amount of 2.3 million instead of the actual USD 3.95 million it raised), the scale of resources mobilized by UNDP appears average, not exceptional but also not very low. The ER sector funding was consistent with the funding level of the entire appeal, just below 40%.

**The organization immediately recognized<sup>37</sup> the importance of resource mobilization and the role that the private sector could play in the Ecuador context.** RM is mentioned regularly during CB meetings but there is no recorded follow up at HQ level, in particular with regards to bilateral donors (except Kazakhstan). Due to personnel turnover since the crisis, it has not been possible to interview anyone in BERA involved with RM for the Ecuador earthquake to verify what initiatives measures taken. Nevertheless, given the difficult RM environment (few donors and a strong Government channeling most of the funds to national entities), more support on resource mobilization from BERA and RBLAC at New York and capitals level would have been useful.

**Despite recognizing the importance of resource mobilization, a Resource Mobilization Action Plan (RMAP) or a RM strategy was not formally developed, and there were no RM Advisors deployed with SURGE.** This might be due to the initial very positive projections of USD 80 millions in two years as recorded in the SURGE Plan; however, when they fell through, it would have been convenient to reassess the need for a RM strategy and the deployment of a RM Advisor. CO staff interviewed has discordant views on the need for a RM Advisor.

**Several key informants interviewed,<sup>38</sup> including from the CO, consider in hindsight that UNDP could have accepted participating in CERF, despite the halving of its proposal from the initial request, and the strong**

<sup>36</sup> Information on funds received is posted voluntarily on FTS therefore there are frequently gaps in data recorded. For example UNDP raised USD 3.95 millions but only 2.3 are recorded in FTS. However the comparison more than exact numbers serves to give an idea of the scale of fundraising in each disaster.

<sup>37</sup> The issue of RM is raised at the first Crisis Board Meeting.

<sup>38</sup> Not all stakeholders agree with this finding.

**resistance and tensions with other humanitarian organizations. Others believe that UNDP took the right decision in withdrawing, as the reduction of funds (potentially allocated to UNDP) to assign them to another organization was unacceptable.**

While recognizing the difficult situation UNDP faced, there are several reasons for maintaining UNDP presence in CERF: additional USD 250,000 could have been employed to address the needs of the population, for example through pilot projects. Funds invested at the beginning of a crisis frequently have a “seed” effect if they are used to showcase activities that can later be expanded. Capacity to deliver results is one of the key factors influencing donors’ decisions and having funds early in the response to show what an agency can do is critical and proportionally more important than achieving the same amount of funds later in the response. UNDP’s pilot projects were quite inexpensive and with the CERF funds more pilots could have been established, or the same projects could have been started in more areas. According to the CO, the pilot project in Las Gilces cost around USD 45,000 and was the basis for the Japanese funding of USD 300,000. The En Marcha component of the pilot, also in Las Gilces, brought about USD 600,000 in funding, while the Puerto Cañitas pilot was the origin for the ECHO funding for USD 952,000.

On the other side, UNDP considered that it was not possible to reduce its proposal (initially of USD 500,000) to USD 250,000 and that if it could not be funded completely then it would be withdrawn; that there was an unfair treatment of the organization leading to the reduction in prospective funds, to which UNDP would not consent. The hypothesis advanced by some informants that the Ecuador case influenced CERF allocations in following crises in LAC, could not be verified.

**Virtually in every crisis, UNDP faces challenges from the rest of the humanitarian community (often including the Humanitarian Coordinator who has the final decision) in applying for CERF Rapid Response Funds, as its activities are not considered “life-saving”.** They are time-critical and can be functional to the delivery of humanitarian assistance, especially in case of debris management after an earthquake. Negotiation is possible, but it requires a lot of advocacy to change perceptions and misconceptions. UNDP should adopt a longer-term approach and advocate for ER throughout the year, building consensus among donors and within the humanitarian and development community, so that when the competition for limited funds takes place, UNDP has better chances to receive the resources it needs. The use of the correct language, showing the criticality of UNDP’s interventions, is also recommended.

**It is important to note that resource mobilization should not become an end in itself, but it is a means to address the needs of the population and the gaps in the response.** These objectives can be achieved in different ways, not just through direct RM. As a middle-income country without a traditional strong donor base, RM is difficult in Ecuador, even in the case of a disaster. In addition, the Government took a very prominent role and required that most of the funding from IFIs be channeled through national institutions. This has narrowed UNDP’s direct RM opportunities. However, it might not be necessary to mobilize resources directly: in such a context, a more strategic approach would be to influence the use of the funds the Government has available, so that they address the needs of the population and especially of the most vulnerable. In the case of Ecuador for example, the National Committee for Reconstruction reported designing together with UNDP a co-paying system and vouchers for house reconstruction. Another example of indirect results is the Tarqui market project: UNDP supported the local government in redesigning a market space for the small commerce in Manta. Afterwards, the Committee for National Reconstruction selected the project to be funded with reconstruction funds (approximately USD 8 millions).

**Alternative RM options can include: approaching philanthropic foundations based in the country or with ties to the country affected by the disaster and engaging the private sector through their corporate social responsibility.** In fact, this is one of the developments of the World Humanitarian Summit: The Connecting Businesses Initiative (CBI) that links the private sector with initiatives on disaster preparedness, emergency response and recovery. While Ecuador is not yet part of this network, given the permanent disaster risks and

vulnerability of the country and the RM limitations discussed above, it could be of interest for UNDP to advocate for Ecuador to join CBI.

**In a middle-income country like Ecuador, resource mobilization efforts should continue to target private citizens and the diaspora.** The diaspora community in particular should be considered as a primary target as individuals are emotionally linked to the country of origin, likely to have family in the country, willing but unable to directly help due to the distance, but also, likely to have a better economic situation. Traditional humanitarian fundraising tools (like the Flash Appeal) are targeted to institutional donors, not to private individuals. Globally, UNDP should look into developing fundraising tools that speak to a different audience, associated with communications initiatives. While small in scale, the experience of crowdfunding for the “Turismo Solidario” Competition is interesting and should be further explored.

**UNDP showed remarkable creativity in developing a very successful communications and resource mobilizations campaign, aimed more at the public and the private sector than at traditional donors.** The campaign is discussed more extensively in the Communications section of this chapter. Thanks to the personal contacts of a staff, UNDP was able to engage with the IDV football team, who donated the revenues from several games of the Copa Libertadores. This was a fortunate coincidence but was also made possible by the trust and transparency that UNDP has built in the country.

**In the case of more traditional donors, they had multiple reasons to support UNDP.** The main factors that influenced their decisions were (not in order of importance): a previous relationship with the organization, trust in the organization and its methods of work; coincidence between priorities of the donor and UNDP proposed interventions; mandate and expertise of the organization; capacity and speed of delivery; gaps in early recovery funding (as other sectors were better covered by other donors); Government priorities. Some adverse elements reported were bureaucracy hurdles and delays; lack of understanding by donors decision-makers of UNDP’s mandate on early recovery.

When advocating with donors, in particular with the more development-oriented ones, UNDP should stress the foundational role early recovery can play in building the basis for recovery and development, and leverage the advantage created by the WHS and the “New Way of Working” philosophy. Also, ER needs should be well articulated and analyzed in the main assessments, like MIRA and PDNA. Early recovery should feature explicitly as a priority in these documents.

### 3. Concluding observations

This report articulates for each of the subjects explored, the challenges encountered and lessons learned in the Ecuadorian crisis, and further offers recommendations to improve UNDP’s performance on crisis response, early recovery and recovery at the different levels. Below we summarize the key lessons learned and make some final observation on Ecuador’s experience.

**1. Middle-income countries with high human development and strong national capacity require a different approach.** The CO naturally understood this, and was able to organize the response according to the context: it adapted successfully some programmatic tools used for development to the emergency situation; it used an innovative approach to resource mobilization by engaging with private citizens and the private sector, involved artists and athletes in its advocacy and RM efforts; it also leveraged existing national capacities and made an intentional effort to strengthen it even further, contracting nationals in addition to internal experts and by pairing national and internationals to ensure transfer of knowledge and sustainability. This model should be taken as an example by UNDP and applied in similar contexts.

**2. UNDP's progressive professionalization on crisis response is bearing fruits and the organization should be strategic in its commitment and investments to increase results even further.** The Crisis response SOPs, the Crisis Response Packages, Fast Track Procedures, SURGE support and all the other tools available are effective in supporting a CO with limited preparedness and limited experience in crisis management to deliver a positive response. UNDP should continue to develop and improve its standards, processes and tools, differentiate them to address effectively diverse contexts and needs, and invest adequately in specialized human resources.

**3. Despite the progress made over the years, UNDP still struggles on the acceptance of early recovery legitimacy in crisis contexts, and on being given the space, priority, and resources it deserves.** To this effect, the results of the 2016 World Humanitarian Summit, and the renewed commitment of the international community to transcending the humanitarian and development divide represent an opportunity not to be missed to ensure the integration of early recovery in crisis responses.

**This AAR concludes that the CO profited from the corporate support provided through crisis response and SURGE mechanisms, and that UNDP as an organization also benefits from the expertise developed and tools created through this experience, on which it should capitalize to further improve its performance on crisis response, early recovery and recovery.**

## 4. Recommendations

The following section includes key recommendations based on the findings, grouped according to the areas of analysis, and including two crosscutting subjects (crisis preparedness and gender equality) that touch across several areas. In brackets the suggested entities mainly responsible for the implementation of the recommendations (others might also contribute).

### *Crisis response preparedness*

- ☑ **[ECO]**<sup>39</sup> *Given the permanent and the recurring disaster risks faced by Ecuador, the CO should continue strengthening its internal preparedness, by regularly exposing key staff (programmes and operations alike) to all corporate support facilities and mechanisms, by allowing the deployment of qualified staff, especially national staff, to other operations as SURGE support or First Responders (a good practice the CO is already implementing), and by ensuring the annual update and implementation of Minimum Preparedness Actions (MPAs) and of the BCP. In case of a heightened risk of disaster, ensure Advanced Preparedness Actions are completed on time.*
- ☑ **[ECO]** *The CO should test its preparedness and capacity by conducting internal emergency simulations or participating in interagency ones that feature key disaster risks, like a Cotopaxi eruption. Based on the simulation results, the CO shall improve and update its preparedness, addressing identified weaknesses.*
- ☑ **[ECO]** *The CO as part of its preparedness efforts should engage regularly with Government (especially with national-level entities involved in disaster risk management), donors and partners on the relevance of Early Recovery in emergencies, building on the WHS commitment on transcending the humanitarian-development divide towards collective outcomes, as articulated in the "New Way of Working" approach, preparing the space for UNDP's role on ER during a crisis.*
- ☑ **[ECO]** *The CO should invest in communications preparedness activities, including developing in advance customizable communications products and messages for key target audiences on the main risks the*

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<sup>39</sup> [ECO] refers to Ecuador Country Office, while [COs] recommendations are valid for COs in general.

country faces (for example the Cotopaxi eruption). It should ensure that both programme managers and communications staff are trained on communications in emergency.

- ☑ **[CRU] [RB] [BMS]** CRU, BMS and Regional Bureau should invest more in the preparedness of Operations teams across regions, by:
  - ✓ Expanding the component on Operations and special measures (previously called FTPs) in CRP/preparedness trainings;
  - ✓ Continue to train the Operations Managers of all COs, and one or two key staff per CO;
  - ✓ Continue to increase internal capacity through FR/SURGE deployments and detail missions of COs Operations staff.
- ☑ **[CRU]** CRU should ensure regular distribution and communication on CRPs to increase their diffusion and knowledge by COs; evaluate the opportunity of translating into French, Spanish and Arabic the CRPs components currently in English (only Guidance Notes are translated).

#### Gender equality

- ☑ **[CB] [CMST]** The Crisis Board should ensure it addresses gender issues as provided for by the SOPs; during these meetings it should hold the CO's Management accountable on UNDP's gender commitments (dedicate 15% of its funds to address women specific needs, advance gender equality, empower women and girls as the primary objective), including by requesting reports on progress towards the commitments; the CMST with technical support from BPPS/Regional Gender Specialists should ensure regular follow-up on gender-related decisions and provide technical assistance to the CO if needed.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS/Gender]** CRU and BPPS/Gender Team should review the specific ToRs of the FR and SURGE deployees before any specific deployment to ensure that they include clear and measurable responsibilities and deliverables on gender, linked to the crisis, in line with UNDP's global commitment on gender taken at the World Humanitarian Summit (15% of resources dedicated to gender equality and women's empowerment); gender expertise should be included as a desired requirement and prioritizing criterion for deployment; SURGE deployees performance should be assessed— where applicable - against the gender-related deliverables included in ToRs.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS/Gender]** CRU with the support of the BPPS Gender Team should mainstream gender into the First Responders and SURGE trainings, expanding from thematic sessions to all relevant subjects (for example assessments, response planning, recovery planning, signature products, case studies and simulations, and so on).
- ☑ **[ECO]** With support from BPPS and the Regional Gender Team, the CO should take a more systematic and structured approach towards gender equality and women's empowerment, including: assessments, programme planning and implementation, and programme monitoring, and ensure the same approach in the Early Recovery sector. If needed, technical support and specialized expertise are available to help the CO fulfill UNDP's global commitments on gender (dedicate 15% of its funds to address women specific needs, advance gender equality, empower women and girls as the primary objective)
- ☑ **[COs] [BPPS]** UNDP COs with the support of PDNA Advisors if deployed, and in collaboration with UN Women if present in-country, should ensure the mainstreaming of gender issues in the entirety of PDNAs, particularly in sectorial analyses, so that different needs of women and men, boys and girls can be addressed in the recovery and reconstruction plans that are developed on the basis of these assessments.
- ☑ **[CRU]** CRU, with the support from BPPS/Gender, should include the gender dimension in standard AARs Terms of Reference and a minimum number of questions to orient AARs on the subject.

#### Corporate support

- ☑ **[CRU]** When developing the SURGE Plan, the Planning Team and the CO should assess the need for BPPS technical support to the CO design of the Recovery Framework/Plan, and if pertinent, include it as part of SURGE support towards the end of the SURGE phase. If any BPPS staff are deployed as First Responders, they can contribute to this analysis by joining the SURGE Planning Team. After the end of the SURGE phase, further BPPS technical support shall be funded through other mechanisms different from SURGE.
- ☑ **[CRU]** As the situation after a disaster is very dynamic, UNDP should provide—for a review—of the SURGE Plan two/three months after the initial formulation (either remotely or through a CRU/RB/BPPS joint mission, depending on the specifics of each crisis). This review should be factored in the initial version of the SURGE Plan; it should include a programmatic analysis of the CO portfolio and crisis response implemented; its result could be either an evolution of the initial SURGE Plan which takes into account the changes in the country situation and the potential resources that can be mobilized, or the basis to design long-term recovery programmes, the Recovery Framework for the CO or support to national recovery planning.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS]** CRU and BPPS should articulate more in detail the transition between the crisis and recovery phases by outlining specific roles and responsibilities of UNDP's offices and departments, possible support available and how COs can access it.
- ☑ **[CB]** The CB should ensure the regularity of the CMST, created to support and monitor the implementation of CB decisions and CO required support; to this effect it should appoint a CMST Coordinator that is not deployed elsewhere during the first weeks of the crisis.
- ☑ **[CRU]** AARs should be conducted maximum after 6 months from the response as indicated in the SOPs.

#### Deployment of experts

- ☑ **[CRU] [COs]** UNDP should take measures to reduce the risk of unsuccessful deployments by improving the selection and matching of SURGE profiles with their assignments:
  - ✓ CRU should expand the Spanish-speaking profiles in the roster by engaging with LAC COs to identify potential candidates (both practitioners and in academia) and by engaging with Latin American qualified diaspora;
  - ✓ COs should negotiate in advance with national authorities and receiving entities, defining precise ToRs of SURGE positions, adapted to the crisis and clearly indicating the specific support required and deliverables expected; these can also be reviewed after a while as crisis situations are highly dynamic and needs might change;
  - ✓ UNDP should provide for dynamic assessment of the effectiveness of SURGE deployments by establishing benchmarks or progressive deliverables in the ToRs, and for the rapid reallocation of SURGE deployees to different tasks or institutions in case of a change in circumstances or support required.
- ☑ **[CRU]** If UNDP wants to position itself globally on some of its signature products, for example as the go-to organization for debris management in an emergency, it should hire full-time experts who are global authorities on the chosen subject and who develop knowledge through practice, studies and publications. If funding limitations would not allow hiring full-time experts, UNDP should consider sourcing experts from the private sector (accepting the higher cost this entails) for short-term needs.

#### Programmes

- ☑ **[ECO]** The CO should strengthen its programmatic impact by ensuring a systematic design of interventions as mutually reinforcing and integrated, in particular those that aim at building or strengthening resilience.
- ☑ **[CRU] [BPPS]** CRU and BPPS should review the Ecuador CO adaptation of the two livelihoods methodologies (*En Marcha!* and *Creciendo con Su Negocio*) as potential tools for inclusion into the CRPs.

## Operations

- ☑ **[BMS]** CRU/BMS/RB should continue to disseminate regularly information on special measures (previously called FTPs) for better awareness of COs on the procedures and policies available for countries in crisis
- ☑ **[BMS]** UNDP should assess the added value of all documentation required before contracting a vendor or a partner in crisis response, balancing rapidity of implementation with due diligence and accountability.

## Interagency coordination and engagement with broader response

- ☑ **[CRU] [GCER]** UNDP, in collaboration with the members of the Global Cluster on Early Recovery (GCER), could lead the development and global endorsement of Early Recovery Standards complementary to the Sphere Standards, taking advantage of the opportunity presented by the New Way of Working. This should be done in addition to the integration of ER in existing standards (already occurring).
- ☑ **[COs]** During a crisis UNDP COs must engage robustly on cluster/sector lead responsibilities, taking a proactive approach to building consensus around early recovery; in case of limited resources available to ER cluster/sector members and gaps in the response, UNDP COs should advocate with Government, donors and humanitarian agencies to ensure that early recovery gaps are addressed through the resources of other clusters/sectors, by taking a cross-cluster approach to early recovery.
- ☑ **[RBLAC]** UNDP, together with the World Bank and the European Union, should negotiate an agreement with ECLAC on needs assessments after a crisis, with the corresponding standard procedures and methodology to be used in case of crises in Latin America and the Caribbean.
- ☑ **[COs] [BPPS]** In PDNA or similar assessment exercises, UNDP should continue to emphasize the “soft” components of recovery, in particular the public policies, systems and governance that foster recovery beyond reconstruction.

## Communications

- ☑ **[ECO]** UNDP communications products and campaigns should highlight, together with the agency work, the activities of the ER cluster/sector, thus fulfilling its sector’s lead responsibility to advocate for and engage on behalf of the entire ER cluster/sector.
- ☑ **[COs] [RB]** UNDP should continue ensuring maximum visibility in key humanitarian communication products like SitReps, especially at the beginning of a crisis when information is scarce and SitReps are one of the main sources of information for donors and humanitarian partners alike.
- ☑ **[RB] [BERA]** In middle-income countries where opportunities for traditional RM are limited, UNDP should expand its RM strategy by imitating Ecuador’s example with communications campaigns aimed at individual donations. Communications campaigns should involve Goodwill Ambassadors, celebrities, artists, athletes and others with high social mobilization potential in the country, leveraging their social media presence to engage both the country’s citizens and diaspora. It is recommended to identify possible Goodwill Ambassadors (or similar roles) for middle-income countries and engage them in communications for UNDP, not only for emergencies but also for non-crisis activities.

## Resource Mobilization

- ☑ **[CB]** The Crisis Board should ensure a stricter adherence to the SOPs on Resource Mobilization (by verifying that a RM mobilization strategy, even if basic, is always developed and that it is reviewed in case of major changes in the expected funding) and it should demand dedicated support to the CO from BERA and the respective RB. In case of a difficult RM environment with limited opportunities for raising funds; the respective scope and interplay of BERA’s and RB’s resource mobilization support to a CO during crisis response should be better defined in the SOPs and in practice.

- ☑ **[BERA]** *BERA should develop guidance on RM strategies for middle-income countries that take an alternative approach to RM, target private citizens, diaspora, philanthropic foundations and the private sector, taking example from fundraising strategies in Western countries by other humanitarian and development organizations and exploring new fundraising strategies like crowd-funding.*
- ☑ **[ECO]** *The CO, with support from CRU and BERA, should evaluate the opportunity of joining the Connecting Business Initiatives.*

## Annexes

### Annex 1: After Action Review Terms of Reference



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### Annex 2: Desk review bibliography

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## Annex 3: List of people interviewed

Stakeholders have been engaged with different modalities; either by in-person or Skype semi-structured interviews, during field mission visits, or in focused group discussions:

| Name                | Function     | Institution/Organization | Method |
|---------------------|--------------|--------------------------|--------|
| <b>UNDP Ecuador</b> |              |                          |        |
| Diego Zorrilla      | Former RC/HC | UN Ecuador               | KII    |

|                                            |                                                                                   |                                                               |                                  |
|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Nuno Queiros                               | Deputy Resident Representative                                                    | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Carlo Ruiz                                 | Coordinator, Emergency and Reconstruction Unit                                    | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Enriqueta Baquero                          | Chief Operations                                                                  | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| José Martino                               | Chief Communications                                                              | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Carla Gomez                                | En Marcha Coordinator                                                             | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Nury Bermudez                              | Risk Management Officer                                                           | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Maria Helena Henriquez                     | Chief of sub-office Manta                                                         | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Armando Costa                              | Programme Officer                                                                 | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Ana María Varela                           | Chief, Small Grants Programme                                                     | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Tatiana Moreno                             | HIP                                                                               | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | KII                              |
| Valeria NNN, Paulina Erazo                 | UNDP CO staff involved in the earthquake response                                 | UNDP CO Ecuador                                               | Group interview                  |
| <b>UNDP</b>                                |                                                                                   |                                                               |                                  |
| Xavier Hernández                           | First Responder / CRU                                                             | CRU                                                           | KII                              |
| Ugo Blanco                                 | First Responder / RBLAC; also CMST Coordinator                                    | RBLAC                                                         | KII                              |
| Carmen Morales                             | First Responder / Comms and SURGE Planning Team; Comms Specialist                 | UNDP CO Guatemala                                             | KII                              |
| Alfonso Ortega                             | First Responder / Operations and SURGE Planning Team; Procurement Specialist;     | UNDP CO Paraguay                                              | KII                              |
| Audra Macanskas                            | Procurement Specialist                                                            | SURGE                                                         | KII                              |
| Diego Antoni                               | Policy Specialist (Governance Gender Conflict Prevention)                         | BPPS                                                          | KII                              |
| Eugenia Pira Lopez                         | Team Leader Gender                                                                | Regional Hub Panama                                           | KII                              |
| Krishna Vatsa                              | Recovery Team Leader                                                              | BPPS, BERA                                                    | KII                              |
| Bettina Woll                               | SURGE Planning Team Leader                                                        | CRU                                                           | KII                              |
| Jeannette Fernandez                        | SPT Recovery Advisor; also SURGE – PDNA Coordinator                               | CRU                                                           | KII                              |
| Jacinda Fairholm                           | Regional advisor DRR a.i.                                                         | Regional Hub Panama                                           | KII                              |
| John Wiater, Jorge Garcia,                 | SURGE Government Advisors (Senior Recovery Adv to VP, Reconstruction)             | n/a                                                           | KII                              |
| Carolina Dreikorn                          | SURGE – ER Cluster Coordinator                                                    | n/a                                                           | KII                              |
| Fabrizio Andreuzzi                         | Crisis Response and Preparedness Specialist                                       | CRU                                                           | KII                              |
| Jonas Mfouatie                             | Crisis Response Coordinator                                                       | CRU                                                           | KII                              |
| Notonegoro                                 | Management Specialist                                                             | BMS                                                           | KII                              |
| Thorsten Kallnischkies                     | Demolition Specialist                                                             | MSB (Standby Partner)                                         | Group interview                  |
| <b>National authorities</b>                |                                                                                   |                                                               |                                  |
| Carlos Bernal                              | Secretario Técnico de Reconstrucción                                              | Committee for Reconstruction and Reactivation of Productivity | KII                              |
| Erica Sarate                               | Punto focal agricultura                                                           | Ministry Agriculture (MAGAP)                                  | KII                              |
| Ricardo Zambrano                           | Advisor                                                                           | Ministry of Industries and Productivity                       | KII                              |
| Saskya Lugo                                | Former Advisor to the Minister of the Coordinating Ministry of Social Development | Minister of the Coordinating Ministry of Social Development   | KII                              |
| <b>Local authorities and beneficiaries</b> |                                                                                   |                                                               |                                  |
| NNN and Zayda Peñafiel                     | Director Fomento Productivo; International Cooperation coordinator                | Gobierno Provincial de Manabí                                 | Field mission to Manabí Province |
| Virgilio Briones                           | Portomeracados                                                                    | Portoviejo                                                    |                                  |
| Agripina                                   | beneficiaries                                                                     | Manabí province                                               |                                  |
| Carlos and Susana                          | beneficiaries                                                                     | Manabí province                                               |                                  |

|                                |                                                         |                                       |                 |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Bolivar Aragundi               | Former Community President of Las Gilces, beneficiaries | Municipality of Portoviejo            |                 |
| <b>Donors and others</b>       |                                                         |                                       |                 |
| Santiago Morales               | General manager IDV                                     | Football club Independiente del Valle | KII             |
| Pablo Torrealba                | Ecuador focal point                                     | ECHO                                  | KII             |
| Carlo Miglioli, and Andrea NNN | Co-Directors                                            | Italy-Ecuador development fund        | Group interview |
| Pablo Galarza                  | OCHA Focal Point in Ecuador                             | OCHA                                  | KII             |

## Annex 4: Summary of interview/survey/focus group questions

### Key informants interview guideline

Name:

Title:

Office/Unit:

Role in crisis response:

Date:

### Questions

1. Can you please give me a brief overview of your role in the crisis response?
2. In your opinion, what are the key successes of this response?
3. For each of them, can you indicate the main enabling factors?
4. What were the key challenges encountered? What didn't work?
5. For each of the challenges, can you list one or more reasons?
6. *[In-depth questions depending on the role of the informant in the response – see data collection table]*
7. What are your key recommendations for UNDP's future crisis responses?
8. Is there anything else you would like to add?

*Documents to be shared: ex. Informant ToRs, deliverables produced, other docs.*

Thank you.

## Annex 5: Data collection matrix

**Primary question:** How effective was UNDP's overall crisis response in the aftermath of the earthquake?

### Context and operational environment

|                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Questions (ToRs)                                                                       |
| Elements of the context and operational environment that have influenced UNDP response |

### A - How timely and efficient was the use of the SOPs tools and mechanisms for crisis response?

|                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Questions (ToRs)                                                              |
| A1 - How well did the Crisis Board and CMST function?                         |
| A2 - Assess the timeliness and quality of First Responders deployed           |
| A3 - How well did the coordination within UNDP HQs /Regional Hub and CO work? |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A4 - Was the SURGE planning team deployed at the right time, with the right team leadership and composition? Did the SURGE planning team successfully integrated the contributions from the country office in formulating the SURGE Plan? |
| A5 - How well did the Country-level decision-making function?                                                                                                                                                                             |
| A6 - Were resource allocation decisions timely and appropriate?                                                                                                                                                                           |

**B - How efficient was the UNDP SURGE mechanism (i.e. the UNDP staff and experts deployment mechanism)?**

|                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Questions (ToRs)                                                                                     |
| B1 - How do you assess the overall contribution of the SURGE mechanisms to UNDP's response?          |
| B2 - Was country preparedness/contingency adequate?                                                  |
| B3 - Was the timeliness and quality of deployees appropriate and relevant to the needs in the field? |
| B4 - How do you assess the flexibility of the SURGE mechanism with the evolving needs of the CO?     |
| B5 - Was the follow up mission useful to plan the transition from SURGE support to                   |
| B7 - How useful was the stand-by-partner deployment mechanism?                                       |

**C - How effective was UNDP engagement with the broader response (including government, humanitarian partners and other partners such as the private sector and donors)?**

|                                                                                                                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Questions (ToRs)                                                                                                                                                         |
| C1 - The extent of UNDP's coordination and cooperation with key humanitarian partners on the ground;                                                                     |
| C2 - How was the relationship and coordination with the Government of Ecuador?                                                                                           |
| C3 - How do you assess the process and results of the PDNA and UNDP's participation?                                                                                     |
| C4 - UNDP's leadership of the Early Recovery working group on the ground in supporting recovery and UNDP capacity to attract partners and resources                      |
| C5 - Support on Early Recovery to the Humanitarian Coordinator and the Humanitarian Country Team.                                                                        |
| C6 - Assess UNDP's role and actions vis-à-vis the private sector                                                                                                         |
| C7 - UNDP's ability to link immediate early recovery to longer term recovery efforts;                                                                                    |
| C8 - UNDP's ability to build synergies and mainstream the recovery agenda in the needs assessment processes (such as MIRA and DNA) and humanitarian funding instruments; |

**D - How relevant and effective was the programmatic response of UNDP?**

|                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Questions (ToRs)                                                                                                                                                            |
| D1 - How was the overall programmatic performance, the pertinence of UNDP's recovery programme formulation and the choices that were made in terms of programme priorities? |
| D2 - Were adjustments made to the existing country programme in response to the crisis?                                                                                     |
| D3 - Assess the sustainability of UNDP's programmatic activities and function performed by SURGE Advisors.                                                                  |
| D4 - Examine the role SURGE Advisors played in programme development and implementation, programme realignment and resource mobilization;                                   |
| D5 - Look at whether the response was in line with the commitments of the WHS in terms of bridging the humanitarian development divide                                      |
| D6 - Were the Crisis Response packages useful?                                                                                                                              |
| D7 - Was the implementation of pilot projects relevant for scaling up, UNDP positioning and/or resource mobilization?                                                       |

**E - How effective the operational response of UNDP?**

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Questions (ToRs)                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| E1 - Were exigency measures in put in place (i.e. fast track) effective to ensure effective and timely delivery of support? (procurement, human resources, Relocation of personnel, Establishment of new offices, etc. |
| E2 - Examine the operational bottlenecks and constraints faced by the CO in terms of both operations and programme implementation                                                                                      |
| E3 - Were the operational processes for the establishment of a sub-office adequate?                                                                                                                                    |

**F - How effective were UNDP's external communications and resource mobilisation?**

|                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Questions (ToRs)                                                                                                                      |
| F1 - Examine the timeliness and effectiveness of communication, including relationship with media, and resource mobilization efforts; |

|                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| F2 - Review UNDP's level of success in mobilizing funds from humanitarian funding sources, including but not limited to Flash Appeal and CERF Rapid Response Grant. |
| F3 - Capacity to mobilize resources taking into account the outcomes of the WHS.                                                                                    |
| F4 - Examine internal and external factors that impacted donor funding decisions, identifying areas for improvement. (ex. Elections and Govt position)              |
| F5 - Assess donor response to the UNDP programme, identifying gaps and areas for improvement                                                                        |

## Annex 6: Crisis Board meeting minutes



Ecuador- Earthquake - Crisis Board Meeting 2  
Crisis Board Meet



Crisis Board Meeting 2 minutes.docx



Crisis Board Meeting 3 minutes.docx



Ecuador Crisis Board Meeting #4 final2.



Ecuador Crisis Board Meeting #5.docx

## Annex 7: Matrix of main findings and recommendations



Recommendation  
Matrix\_Ecuador AAR.xlsx